Catechism.

YEAR 2 · UNIT 15 · DAYS 565-602

The New Covenant Inaugurated: Matthew

Matthew 1-28

Jesus as the new Moses, new David, and new Israel. The Kingdom arrives in a person.

UNIT ANCHOR VERSE

"You are the Christ, the Son of the living God."

MATTHEW 16:16

Psalm 1 beside the Sermon on the Mount. Psalms 146 and 147 beside the healings. Psalms 2 and 110 beside the Transfiguration. Psalm 118 in Holy Week.

UNIT 15

In this unit

WEEK 81

565	Matthew 1:1-2:23	*Reading*
566	Matthew 3:1-4:25	*Reading*
567	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 82

568	Matthew 5:1-20	*Reading*
569	Matthew 5:21-48	*Reading*
570	Matthew 6:1-34	*Reading*
571	Matthew 6:5-15; Luke 11:1-13	*Doctrine*
572	Matthew 7:1-29	*Reading*
573	Psalm 1	*Psalm*
574	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 83

575	Psalm 146	*Psalm*
576	Psalm 147:1-11	*Psalm*
577	Matthew 8:1-9:38	*Reading*
578	Matthew 10:1-11:30	*Reading*
579	Matthew 12:1-13:23	*Reading*
580	Psalm 78:1-16	*Psalm*
581	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 84

582	Psalm 25	*Psalm*
583	Matthew 13:24-14:36	*Reading*
584	Matthew 15:1-16:28	*Reading*
585	Matthew 17:1-18:35	*Reading*
586	Psalm 2	*Psalm*

587	Psalm 110	*Psalm*
588	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 85

589	Matthew 19:1-20:34	*Reading*
590	Matthew 21:1-22:14	*Reading*
591	Matthew 22:15-23:39	*Reading*
592	Matthew 24:1-25:46	*Reading*
593	Psalm 118	*Psalm*
594	Matthew 26:1-46	*Reading*
595	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 86

596	Matthew 26:47-27:31	*Reading*
597	Matthew 27:32-66	*Reading*
598	Matthew 28:1-20	*Reading*
599	Deuteronomy 6:4; Matthew 28:18-20; 2 Corinthians 13:14	*Doctrine*
600	Matthew 28:18-20; Romans 6:1-4; Acts 2:38-41; Colossians 2:11-12	*Doctrine*
601	Review and Reflection	*Review*
602	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

DAY 565 · WEEK 81

Matthew 1:1-2:23

The genealogy; the birth; the Magi, new Israel begins

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Reading · 48 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Matthew 1:1-2:23. The New Testament opens with a list of names. Read it as the final page of the Old Testament's story, then follow the child from Bethlehem to Egypt and back to Nazareth.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After four hundred years of prophetic silence, the first words of the New Testament are "The book of the genealogy of Jesus Christ, the son of David, the son of Abraham." Matthew was a tax collector who became one of the Twelve, and he writes mainly for Jewish readers. His aim is to show that Jesus is the one the whole Old Testament was waiting for. He quotes or echoes Israel's Scriptures more than any other Gospel writer, and he says again and again that something happened "to fulfill what the Lord had spoken by the prophet."

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The book of the genealogy of Jesus Christ, the son of David, the son of Abraham" (1:1).
2. "And Judah the father of Perez and Zerah by Tamar" (1:3).
3. "And Salmon the father of Boaz by Rahab, and Boaz the father of Obed by Ruth" (1:5).
4. "You shall call his name Jesus, for he will save his people from their sins" (1:21).
5. "And they shall call his name Immanuel (which means, God with us)" (1:23).
6. "Where is he who has been born king of the Jews? For we saw his star when it rose and have come to worship him" (2:2).
7. "And you, O Bethlehem, in the land of Judah, are by no means least among the rulers of Judah" (2:6).

8 “Out of Egypt I called my son” (2:15).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Matthew’s genealogy is a short history of the covenants. It begins with Abraham, to whom God promised a blessing for all nations, and moves to David, to whom God promised a throne that would never end. It ends at the exile and then with Jesus. Matthew arranges it in three sets of fourteen, a pattern that is itself a quiet claim: David’s line, broken in Babylon, has now arrived at its Messiah.

Notice who is in the list. Four women are named, which was unusual in a genealogy: Tamar, Rahab, Ruth, and the wife of Uriah. Several were outsiders and some were involved in scandal. Matthew is telling us at the outset that the Messiah comes through the real, messy story of sinners and foreigners, and that grace has been at work in his family tree all along.

The birth story is told from Joseph’s side. He is a righteous man who plans to quietly end the engagement, and God steps in. The name Jesus means “the LORD saves,” and the angel gives its meaning: he will save his people from their sins. That is a bigger rescue than overthrowing Rome. Then Isaiah’s promise is quoted: Immanuel, God with us. The book will end with Jesus saying, “I am with you always,” so the whole Gospel is framed by that promise.

In chapter 2, foreign astrologers come to worship the new king while the king in Jerusalem is troubled and the religious experts know where he will be born but do not go. Herod tries to kill the child. Jesus is taken to Egypt and brought back, and Matthew quotes Hosea: “Out of Egypt I called my son.” Hosea was speaking about Israel in the exodus. Matthew sees Jesus as the true Israel, who relives the nation’s story and does what it failed to do.

STEP 5

Connection

Genesis 12:3 promised that all families of the earth would be blessed through Abraham, and the Magi are the first fruits of that. 2 Samuel 7:12-13 is the promise of David’s throne. Isaiah 7:14 is the Immanuel passage you read in Unit 11. Micah 5:2 names Bethlehem. Romans 5:20 says that where sin increased, grace abounded all the more. Galatians 4:4-5 says that in the fullness of time God sent his Son to redeem those under the law.

STEP 6

Application

Read the genealogy aloud, slowly, and thank God for the sinners and outsiders in it. Then thank him that your own story is not too messy for his grace.

Ask what it would mean to treat Jesus as “God with us” in your ordinary Tuesday.

Notice the difference between the Magi and the scribes: one group traveled far to worship, and the other knew the Bible and stayed home. Which are you more like this week?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for keeping every promise to Abraham and David in Jesus.
- Tell him what it means that Jesus came to save his people from their sins.
- Ask him to teach you to worship as the Magi did.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 81

“You shall call his name Jesus, for he will save his people from their sins.”

MATTHEW 1:21

DAY 566 · WEEK 81

Matthew 3:1-4:25

John the Baptist; the baptism; the temptation

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Reading · 49 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Matthew 3:1-4:25. John prepares the way, Jesus is baptized, and the Father speaks. Then Jesus is led into the wilderness, where he is tempted, and he begins to call disciples. Watch how Jesus answers the devil.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Jesus is about thirty years old when his public ministry begins. John the Baptist has been preaching in the Judean wilderness near the Jordan, calling Israel to repent in preparation for the king. Matthew presents what happens at the Jordan and in the wilderness as the start of a new exodus: Israel passed through the sea and was tested for forty years, and now Israel's true Son passes through the water and is tested for forty days.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Repent, for the kingdom of heaven is at hand" (3:2).
2. "Bear fruit in keeping with repentance" (3:8).
3. "I baptize you with water for repentance, but he who is coming after me is mightier than I" (3:11).
4. "Let it be so now, for thus it is fitting for us to fulfill all righteousness" (3:15).
5. "This is my beloved Son, with whom I am well pleased" (3:17).
6. "Then Jesus was led up by the Spirit into the wilderness to be tempted by the devil" (4:1).
7. "It is written, Man shall not live by bread alone, but by every word that comes from the mouth of God" (4:4).

8 “Follow me, and I will make you fishers of men” (4:19).

STEP 4

Interpretation

John’s message is simple: the king is coming, so turn around. The crowds come to be baptized, confessing their sins, but when religious leaders come, John warns them not to rest on being Abraham’s descendants. Fruit, not family, shows repentance.

Then Jesus comes to be baptized, which seems backward. John hesitates, because Jesus has no sins to confess. Jesus says it is fitting “to fulfill all righteousness.” He stands with sinners and takes his place among them, which anticipates the cross. The heavens open, the Spirit descends, and the Father speaks the words that combine Psalm 2 (a royal son) and Isaiah 42 (the servant in whom God delights). Jesus is both the king and the suffering servant.

Immediately the Spirit drives him into the wilderness. Israel failed its testing at hunger, at testing God, and at idolatry. Jesus faces the same three. When he is hungry, he answers with Deuteronomy 8: people live by every word from God’s mouth. When the devil quotes Scripture and tells him to throw himself down, Jesus answers from Deuteronomy 6: do not put the LORD your God to the test. When offered all the kingdoms of the world without a cross, he answers from Deuteronomy 6 again: worship the Lord alone. Every answer is a verse from the book Israel had been given in the wilderness. Jesus succeeds where Israel failed, and he does it by knowing and trusting the word.

Chapter 4 ends with the first disciples leaving their nets and the crowds beginning to gather. The kingdom he announces comes with healing and teaching.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 2:7 and Isaiah 42:1 stand behind the Father’s words at the baptism. Deuteronomy 8:3, 6:16, and 6:13 are the three verses Jesus quotes. Hebrews 4:15 says we have a high priest who in every respect has been tempted as we are, yet without sin. 1 Corinthians 10:1-13 compares Israel’s wilderness failures to our own testing. Ephesians 6:17 calls the word of God the sword of the Spirit.

STEP 6

Application

When you are tempted, answer with a specific verse you know. Choose one this week and memorize it for that purpose.

Notice that Jesus was tempted right after he was told he was God’s beloved Son. Being loved by the Father does not mean being spared trials.

Respond to Jesus' call to follow. What is one "net" you may need to put down?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for standing with sinners at the Jordan and standing firm in the wilderness.

Ask him to teach you to live by every word from God's mouth.

Tell him what you are tempted by.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 81

"You shall call his name Jesus, for he will save his people from their sins."

MATTHEW 1:21

DAY 567 · WEEK 81

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Matthew 1:21 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"You shall call his name Jesus, for he will save his people from their sins."

MATTHEW 1:21

REST

Meditation

An angel speaks these words to Joseph in a dream, and they contain the whole mission of Jesus in one sentence.

"You shall call his name Jesus." The name is the Greek form of Joshua, which means "the LORD saves." Names in Scripture often carry meaning, and this one is a sermon. Joseph does not choose it. God does. Joseph is asked to take the child as his own and to give him the name.

"For he will save." The verb is about rescue. Matthew does not say he will try, or offer help, or point the way. He will save. The child in the manger is the rescuer.

"His people." The people are those who belong to him. In the Old Testament, that meant Israel. By the end of this Gospel, it includes people from every nation who follow him. Matthew begins with a family tree that includes outsiders for a reason.

“From their sins.” This is the surprising part. A first-century Jew would have expected rescue from Rome. Matthew says the deepest problem is not political but moral, and the solution is a Savior who deals with sin itself. He does this at the cross, where he bears it.

Say this verse whenever you wonder what Jesus came to do. He came to save his people from their sins, and that includes you if you belong to him.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you finished the Old Testament and began the New. You read Zechariah’s vision of a fountain, a pierced one, and the LORD as king over all the earth. In Malachi you heard God’s love, his rebuke, and the promise of a messenger and a sun of righteousness. You reviewed the whole Unit 14 story of the return. Then, on the first two days of Matthew, you saw the genealogy that gathers up the covenants of Abraham and David, the virgin birth and the name Jesus, the Magi who came to worship, and the escape to Egypt. You watched John prepare the way, Jesus baptized with the Father’s voice from heaven, and Jesus overcome the devil’s temptations by quoting Deuteronomy. The silence between the Testaments is over, and the promises are arriving in a person.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Matthew’s genealogy includes Tamar, Rahab, and Ruth. What does that tell you about the kind of people Jesus came for?

The name Jesus means “the LORD saves.” In what area of your life do you most need to remember that he saves?

Jesus answered each temptation with Scripture. Which Scripture is helping you stand right now, and which one might you memorize next?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for coming to save his people from their sins.

Thank God for the long story that led to him.

Rest in his salvation.

DAY 568 · WEEK 82

Matthew 5:1-20

The Beatitudes; salt and light; the law fulfilled

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Reading · 20 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Matthew 5:1-20. This is the opening of the Sermon on the Mount. Read the Beatitudes slowly, one at a time, and notice how each begins with a blessing and ends with a promise.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Jesus goes up on a mountain, sits down as a teacher would, and speaks to his disciples while crowds listen. Matthew has just shown Jesus as the new Israel. Now he shows him as the new Moses, giving a teaching from a mountain, as Moses did at Sinai. The Sermon is not a list of requirements for earning God's favor. It is a portrait of life in the kingdom that has arrived, addressed to people who already belong to him.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Blessed are the poor in spirit, for theirs is the kingdom of heaven" (5:3).
2. "Blessed are those who mourn, for they shall be comforted" (5:4).
3. "Blessed are the meek, for they shall inherit the earth" (5:5).
4. "Blessed are those who hunger and thirst for righteousness, for they shall be satisfied" (5:6).
5. "Blessed are the pure in heart, for they shall see God" (5:8).
6. "Blessed are those who are persecuted for righteousness" sake, for theirs is the kingdom of heaven' (5:10).
7. "You are the light of the world. A city set on a hill cannot be hidden" (5:14).

8 “Do not think that I have come to abolish the Law or the Prophets; I have not come to abolish them but to fulfill them” (5:17).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The Beatitudes turn the world’s idea of success upside down. The people called blessed are the poor in spirit, the mourners, the meek, and the persecuted. These are not the ones the world admires. Yet each is promised something: the kingdom, comfort, the earth, satisfaction, mercy, the sight of God. The blessing is not a reward for being good enough. These are people who know their need, and the kingdom belongs to those who know they cannot get there on their own.

The first and last Beatitudes promise the same thing, the kingdom of heaven, which frames the whole list. The ones between them describe what kingdom people are like: they grieve over sin, they are gentle, they long for what is right, they show mercy, they have undivided hearts, and they make peace. And as the verses go on, Jesus tells them to expect opposition.

He then calls his followers salt and light. Salt preserves and flavors, and light shows the way. Both are useless if hidden or diluted. The point is not to draw attention to ourselves but that people “may see your good works and give glory to your Father in heaven.”

Verses 17 to 20 are the hinge. Jesus did not come to throw away the Old Testament. He came to fulfill it, which means to bring it to its intended goal. The law and prophets pointed to him, and he completes what they began. And when he says that our righteousness must exceed that of the scribes and Pharisees, he sets up an impossible standard that only he can meet and then give to us. The rest of the Sermon shows how deep that righteousness goes.

STEP 5

Connection

Exodus 19 and 20 describe the giving of the law from a mountain. Isaiah 61:1-3 promises good news for the poor and comfort for those who mourn. Psalm 37:11 says the meek shall inherit the land. Psalm 24:3-4 asks who may ascend the hill of the LORD, and the answer is the clean of hands and pure of heart. Philippians 2:15 says believers shine as lights in the world. Romans 10:4 says Christ is the end, or goal, of the law for righteousness to everyone who believes.

STEP 6

Application

Pick one Beatitude and ask where it describes you or challenges you. Pray about that specific one today.

Ask what “poor in spirit” would look like in your work, your marriage, or your church. How would you act if you knew you needed God for everything?

Do one visible good work today that points toward the Father, not toward you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to make you poor in spirit, aware of your need.
- Tell him what you hunger and thirst for.
- Ask him to let your light shine so that others give glory to him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 82

“In the same way, let your light shine before others, so that they may see your good works and give glory to your Father who is in heaven.”

MATTHEW 5:16

DAY 569 · WEEK 82

Matthew 5:21-48

The law's true demand, heart-level obedience

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Reading · 28 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Matthew 5:21-48. Jesus takes six commands from the law and goes beneath the surface of each one. Notice the repeated phrase "You have heard that it was said... But I say to you."

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Having said he came to fulfill the law, Jesus now shows what that means. The religious teachers of the day had narrowed the law to outward behavior, often with loopholes. Jesus takes six examples, murder, adultery, divorce, oaths, retaliation, and love for enemies, and shows that God's law was always aimed at the heart. He does not set aside Moses. He reveals what Moses meant.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "You have heard that it was said to those of old, You shall not murder... But I say to you that everyone who is angry with his brother will be liable to judgment" (5:21-22).
2. "So if you are offering your gift at the altar and there remember that your brother has something against you, leave your gift there before the altar and go. First be reconciled to your brother" (5:23-24).
3. "Everyone who looks at a woman with lustful intent has already committed adultery with her in his heart" (5:28).
4. "If your right eye causes you to sin, tear it out and throw it away" (5:29).
5. "Let what you say be simply Yes or No" (5:37).
6. "But I say to you, Do not resist the one who is evil" (5:39).

7. “Love your enemies and pray for those who persecute you” (5:44).
8. “You therefore must be perfect, as your heavenly Father is perfect” (5:48).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Each of the six examples follows the same pattern. Jesus quotes the commandment, and then he goes to the root. Murder starts in anger and contempt. Adultery starts in lust. Faithfulness in speech should not need oaths. Love should not stop at those who love us back. He is not adding new rules but exposing what the old ones always demanded.

The effect is meant to be unsettling. A person who thinks he has kept the law by avoiding murder finds that he has been angry. A person who has avoided adultery finds that he has looked with desire. No one can say, “I have kept all these.” Jesus has made the standard so high that everyone has to see that righteousness cannot be earned. That is why the Beatitudes began with the poor in spirit.

His strong language about tearing out an eye is not a command to self-harm but a way of saying that sin must be dealt with seriously, whatever it costs. And his teaching on retaliation points to a different way of living. Instead of getting even, his people absorb insult and give generously, trusting the Father to be their defender.

The last command is the most demanding: “Be perfect, as your heavenly Father is perfect.” The context is love for enemies. God sends rain and sun on the just and unjust alike, and his children are meant to look like him. “Perfect” here means whole, complete, not partial. Only one person has ever lived this out. That is why the Sermon drives us to Christ, who lived it for us and then gives his Spirit to begin forming it in us.

STEP 5

Connection

1 John 3:15 says everyone who hates his brother is a murderer. James 1:14-15 traces sin from desire to death. Proverbs 4:23 says to guard your heart. Romans 12:17-21 echoes Jesus on overcoming evil with good. Luke 23:34 shows Jesus praying for his enemies on the cross. Romans 5:8 says that while we were still sinners, Christ died for us. Galatians 3:10-14 says Christ redeemed us from the curse of the law.

STEP 6

Application

Think of someone you are angry with. Ask what first step toward reconciliation God might want from you today.

Be honest about one area where outward obedience hides an inward struggle. Confess it to God, who already knows.

Pray for an enemy or a difficult person by name this week.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess the anger, desire, or love that stops short in you.
- Thank Jesus for fulfilling the law you cannot.
- Ask him to change your heart from the inside.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 82

"In the same way, let your light shine before others, so that they may see your good works and give glory to your Father who is in heaven."

MATTHEW 5:16

DAY 570 · WEEK 82

Matthew 6:1-34

Prayer, fasting, treasure, anxiety, the Father in heaven

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Reading · 34 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Matthew 6:1-34. Jesus turns from the law to the practices of the religious life: giving, praying, and fasting. Then he deals with money and anxiety. Notice how often he says “your Father who sees in secret.”

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The second part of the Sermon is about the heart behind devotion. In first-century Judaism, giving, prayer, and fasting were the three marks of a pious person, and it was tempting to do them for the applause of others. Jesus asks his followers to do them for an audience of one. Then he addresses the two great rivals to trust in the Father: money and worry.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Beware of practicing your righteousness before other people in order to be seen by them” (6:1).
2. “But when you give to the needy, do not let your left hand know what your right hand is doing” (6:3).
3. “Go into your room and shut the door and pray to your Father who is in secret” (6:6).
4. “Your Father knows what you need before you ask him” (6:8).
5. “Pray then like this: Our Father in heaven, hallowed be your name” (6:9).
6. “Do not lay up for yourselves treasures on earth… but lay up for yourselves treasures in heaven” (6:19-20).
7. “No one can serve two masters… You cannot serve God and money” (6:24).

8 “But seek first the kingdom of God and his righteousness, and all these things will be added to you” (6:33).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Jesus warns about acting religious for show. The people who give, pray, and fast to be seen get exactly what they wanted, the praise of people, and nothing more. Those who do these things in secret have a Father who sees and will reward. The difference is who we are performing for.

At the center is the model prayer. It starts with “Our Father,” not “My Father,” and with God’s name, his kingdom, and his will before our needs. Then it asks for daily bread, forgiveness, and protection from temptation. Notice that the prayer is short and simple. Jesus says that pagans heap up empty phrases, thinking they will be heard for their many words, but the Father already knows what we need. Prayer is not about informing or persuading God. It is about coming to him as children.

The teaching on forgiveness (6:14-15) is sobering. The forgiven are expected to forgive. This is not a transaction, but it describes the character of those who have truly received mercy.

Then Jesus turns to treasure and worry. We cannot serve both God and money. He points to the birds, which do not farm and yet are fed, and to the lilies, which do not spin and yet are clothed. “Are you not of more value than they?” Anxiety assumes that we are on our own. Jesus says we have a Father. The cure for worry is not simply to try harder to stop, but to seek first the kingdom and trust that the Father will provide. Take one day at a time: “Sufficient for the day is its own trouble.”

STEP 5

Connection

Isaiah 58:6-9 describes the fasting God desires. Luke 11:1-4 gives Luke’s version of the Lord’s Prayer. 1 Timothy 6:6-10 warns about the love of money. Philippians 4:6-7 says not to be anxious, but to pray with thanksgiving and receive God’s peace. 1 Peter 5:7 says to cast all your anxieties on him because he cares for you. Psalm 55:22 says to cast your burden on the LORD. Romans 8:32 says that the God who gave his Son will also give us all things.

STEP 6

Application

Do one act of giving or service this week that no one will know about except God.

Name your biggest worry. Hand it to the Father in prayer, using Jesus’ reasoning: “You are of more value than the birds.”

Pray the Lord's Prayer slowly today, pausing on each phrase.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Pray the Lord's Prayer slowly, pausing at each line to add your own words.
- Ask him for today's bread and to forgive your sins.
- Ask him to loosen your anxiety and teach you to trust your Father.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 82

"In the same way, let your light shine before others, so that they may see your good works and give glory to your Father who is in heaven."

MATTHEW 5:16

DAY 571 · WEEK 82

Matthew 6:5-15; Luke 11:1-13

Prayer

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Doctrine

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Matthew 6:5-15, then Luke 11:1-13. Today is a doctrinal pause on prayer, so you are reading two accounts together. Notice that in Luke the disciples ask Jesus to teach them to pray, and he gives the prayer and then a parable and a promise.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Yesterday you read the Lord's Prayer within the Sermon on the Mount. Luke records a different occasion. Jesus had been praying, and when he finished, one of his disciples said, "Lord, teach us to pray." Jesus gave them the pattern again in a slightly shorter form, and then taught about asking, seeking, and knocking. Together the two passages give a foundation for what the Bible teaches about prayer.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "When you pray, you must not be like the hypocrites" (Matthew 6:5).
2. "Your Father knows what you need before you ask him" (Matthew 6:8).
3. "Our Father in heaven, hallowed be your name" (Matthew 6:9).
4. "Forgive us our debts, as we also have forgiven our debtors" (Matthew 6:12).
5. "Lord, teach us to pray, as John taught his disciples" (Luke 11:1).
6. "Father, hallowed be your name. Your kingdom come" (Luke 11:2).
7. "Ask, and it will be given to you; seek, and you will find; knock, and it will be opened to you" (Luke 11:9).
8. "How much more will the heavenly Father give the Holy Spirit to those who ask him!" (Luke 11:13).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

Prayer is the means by which believers speak to God as their Father through Jesus Christ, in the power of the Holy Spirit. It includes praise, thanksgiving, confession, and petition. God does not need to be informed of what we need, and prayer does not change his purposes. Rather, he has chosen to bring about his purposes through the prayers of his people. We pray in Jesus' name, which means that we come through his work and on his authority, not our own merit. Prayer is not a technique for getting what we want but a relationship in which we are conformed to the Father's will.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Jesus' teaching on prayer begins with how not to pray. Hypocrites pray to be seen, and pagans pile up words. Neither is how a child talks to a father. Jesus says to go into your room, close the door, and pray to your Father in secret. Real prayer is a personal conversation, not a performance.

The prayer itself begins with "Our Father." This word alone changes everything. We are not approaching a distant ruler or a force. Through Christ we are children addressing a Father who loves us. Then come three petitions about God: his name be treated as holy, his kingdom come, his will be done. We start by wanting what he wants. Only then do we turn to ourselves: daily bread, forgiveness, and deliverance from the evil one. The order teaches us what to put first.

Luke adds a story. A man knocks at his friend's door at midnight to borrow bread, and the friend gets up not out of friendship but because of the man's persistence. Jesus' point is a contrast: if even a reluctant neighbor responds, how much more will the Father? So we ask, seek, and knock. The verbs are in the present tense, suggesting continual asking.

And then the surprising conclusion. A father does not give a snake to a child who asks for a fish. If earthly parents, "who are evil," give good gifts, how much more will the heavenly Father give the Holy Spirit to those who ask him? The greatest answer to prayer is not an object but God himself, present in us by his Spirit. This does not mean that every request will be granted as we ask, but that the Father will always give what is good.

STEP 5

Connection

Romans 8:15-16 says we have received the Spirit of adoption by whom we cry "Abba, Father." Romans 8:26-27 says the Spirit helps us in our weakness when we do not know what to pray. John 14:13-14 teaches prayer in Jesus' name. Hebrews 4:16 invites us to approach the throne

of grace with confidence. 1 John 5:14 says that if we ask anything according to his will, he hears us. Philippians 4:6 says to make requests known to God with thanksgiving. James 4:2-3 warns about asking with wrong motives.

STEP 6

Application

Set aside a regular time and place to pray, even for ten minutes. Use the Lord's Prayer as an outline: praise, God's kingdom, daily needs, forgiveness, protection.

Keep a short list of requests you are bringing to the Father, and note when he answers.

Ask for the Holy Spirit, as Jesus invites, and ask specifically for help in a weakness.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God that through Jesus you can call him Father.
- Pray each petition of the Lord's Prayer in your own words.
- Ask him to teach you to pray with persistence.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 82

"In the same way, let your light shine before others, so that they may see your good works and give glory to your Father who is in heaven."

MATTHEW 5:16

DAY 572 · WEEK 82

Matthew 7:1-29

Judging, asking, the narrow way, the two foundations

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Reading · 29 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Matthew 7:1-29. Jesus ends the Sermon with warnings about judging, a call to ask the Father, the narrow gate, false prophets, and the two builders. Pay attention to the last verses of the chapter.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The final chapter of the Sermon moves from describing the kingdom life to urging a response. Jesus warns his hearers against false religion and calls for decision. The Sermon ends not with a list of rules but with a choice between two roads, two trees, and two foundations. Everyone who hears must act.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Judge not, that you be not judged” (7:1).
2. “First take the log out of your own eye, and then you will see clearly to take the speck out of your brother’s eye” (7:5).
3. “Ask, and it will be given to you; seek, and you will find; knock, and it will be opened to you” (7:7).
4. “So whatever you wish that others would do to you, do also to them, for this is the Law and the Prophets” (7:12).
5. “Enter by the narrow gate. For the gate is wide and the way is easy that leads to destruction” (7:13).
6. “You will recognize them by their fruits” (7:16).

7. “Not everyone who says to me, Lord, Lord, will enter the kingdom of heaven, but the one who does the will of my Father” (7:21).

8. “And when Jesus finished these sayings, the crowds were astonished at his teaching, for he was teaching them as one who had authority” (7:28-29).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Jesus does not forbid all discernment, since he later tells us to recognize false prophets by their fruit. He forbids a harsh, hypocritical spirit that picks at others’ faults while ignoring our own. The image of a log in the eye is humorous and deliberate. First deal with yourself, and then you can help your brother with clear sight.

The call to ask, seek, and knock comes back again, because the Christian life depends on a Father who gives. And the Golden Rule sums up the whole ethic: treat others as you want to be treated. It is the Law and the Prophets in a sentence.

Then comes a choice. There are two gates, one wide and easy, and one narrow and hard. There are two kinds of trees and two kinds of fruit. The popular road is not the safe one. Jesus’ warning that some who say “Lord, Lord” will be turned away is one of the most sobering in the Bible. These people did religious things, prophesied, cast out demons, and did mighty works in his name. But he says, “I never knew you.” The test is not activity but a relationship with Christ shown in obedience.

The closing story is of two builders. Both heard the same words. One built on rock and one on sand. The storm tested both, and only the house on the rock stood. The difference was not hearing but doing. The crowds were astonished, because Jesus taught with his own authority, not by quoting other rabbis. The one who has given the Sermon is also the one who will judge. The way to be safe is to build on him.

STEP 5

Connection

Romans 2:1 warns that when you judge another, you condemn yourself. James 1:22-25 says to be doers of the word and not hearers only. Luke 6:46-49 gives the parallel to the two builders. John 10:9: “I am the door; if anyone enters by me, he will be saved.” John 14:6: “I am the way, and the truth, and the life.” Ephesians 2:20 says Christ Jesus himself is the cornerstone. 1 Corinthians 3:11: no one can lay a foundation other than Christ.

STEP 6

Application

Ask where you are looking at the speck in someone else while ignoring your own log. Confess it.

Pick one thing from the Sermon on the Mount that you have heard but not done. Do it this week.

Ask yourself honestly: are you building your life on Christ, or on something that will not survive a storm?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess where you judge others while ignoring your own sin.
- Ask him to help you enter by the narrow way.
- Ask him to build your life on the rock of his words.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 82

"In the same way, let your light shine before others, so that they may see your good works and give glory to your Father who is in heaven."

MATTHEW 5:16

DAY 573 · WEEK 82

Psalm 1

Blessed is the man, the two ways behind the Sermon

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Psalm · 6 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 1. This short psalm is the doorway to the whole Psalter, and its two paths sit right behind the Sermon on the Mount. Read it aloud and compare the tree with the chaff.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 1 has no title and no author, and it opens the book of Psalms by setting two ways of life side by side. After reading Jesus' Sermon, with its two gates, two trees, and two foundations, you can hear that Jesus was drawing on this psalm. It is a wisdom poem that asks the reader to choose.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Blessed is the man who walks not in the counsel of the wicked" (v. 1).
2. "Nor stands in the way of sinners, nor sits in the seat of scoffers" (v. 1).
3. "But his delight is in the law of the LORD, and on his law he meditates day and night" (v. 2).
4. "He is like a tree planted by streams of water that yields its fruit in its season" (v. 3).
5. "And its leaf does not wither" (v. 3).
6. "In all that he does, he prospers" (v. 3).
7. "The wicked are not so, but are like chaff that the wind drives away" (v. 4).
8. "For the LORD knows the way of the righteous, but the way of the wicked will perish" (v. 6).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with a progression: walking, standing, sitting. The person who drifts from listening to the wicked, to lingering with sinners, to settling in with scoffers is on a slide. The blessed person turns away from this and finds his delight in God's law, his instruction, and thinks about it all the time.

The picture of the tree is lovely. It is planted, not wild, so someone has put it where the water is. Its roots go down to the stream, and so it bears fruit in season and its leaf does not wither. A person who is rooted in God's word is not immune to hardship, but he has resources the world does not see.

The wicked are like chaff, the light husk of the grain that blows away when the wheat is threshed. They have no weight and no roots. "The wicked will not stand in the judgment." The psalm ends with the contrast: the LORD knows the way of the righteous, and the way of the wicked will perish. To be known by the LORD is the ultimate security.

Read after Matthew 5 to 7, the psalm gets sharper. Who is the truly blessed man who perfectly delights in the law and never walks with sinners? Jesus. He is the true tree planted by the water, and he is the one who gives his Spirit so that others may be rooted in him. The Beatitudes echo this psalm's first word: "Blessed." The Sermon on the Mount is the same invitation to choose the path of life.

STEP 5

Connection

Jeremiah 17:7-8 uses the same tree image for the one who trusts in the LORD. John 15:5 says, "I am the vine; you are the branches. Whoever abides in me and I in him, he it is that bears much fruit." Matthew 7:24-27 is Jesus' version of the two ways. Joshua 1:8 commands meditating on the book of the law day and night. Colossians 2:6-7 says to be rooted and built up in him. Revelation 22:2 shows the tree of life by the river.

STEP 6

Application

Take five minutes today to meditate on one verse, not just read it. Turn it over and ask what it means.

Ask who or what is shaping your "counsel" right now: the voices you listen to and the company you keep.

Memorize verses 1 to 3 as a picture of the life you want.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God you want to be a tree planted by streams of water.

Ask him to keep you from the counsel of the wicked.

Thank him that he knows your way.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 82

"In the same way, let your light shine before others, so that they may see your good works and give glory to your Father who is in heaven."

MATTHEW 5:16

DAY 574 · WEEK 82

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Matthew 5:16 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"In the same way, let your light shine before others, so that they may see your good works and give glory to your Father who is in heaven."

MATTHEW 5:16

REST

Meditation

This verse comes at the end of Jesus' picture of his followers as the light of the world. It tells us what the light is for.

"In the same way." Jesus has just said that a lamp is not lit and hidden under a basket but put on a stand to give light to all in the house. His followers are like that. The point of a light is to be seen, and the point of being seen is to help others find their way.

"Let your light shine." The light is not manufactured. Jesus has already said, "You are the light of the world." The light comes from him, and he says elsewhere, "I am the light of the world." We reflect what we have received. Our task is not to produce it but to let it be seen and not to hide it out of fear or embarrassment.

“Before others.” Faith is not private only. It is lived in front of people, at work, at home, among neighbors. Others notice how we treat people, how we handle trouble, and how we speak.

“So that they may see your good works.” The good works are real, practical acts of love and honesty. They are the visible side of a changed heart.

“And give glory to your Father who is in heaven.” This is the goal. The aim of shining is not that people admire us, but that they look past us to the Father. Good works are windows, not mirrors. If someone praises you today, pass it up to him.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you walked through the opening of Matthew and the heart of the Sermon on the Mount. You saw Jesus’ birth announced with the name that means “the LORD saves,” the baptism where the Father called him his beloved Son, and the wilderness where Jesus beat the devil by quoting Scripture. In the Sermon, Jesus described the blessed life of kingdom people in the Beatitudes, called you salt and light, and showed what the law really demands: a clean heart, not just clean hands. He taught you to pray, to give and fast in secret, and to trust the Father instead of worrying. Then he asked you to choose between two roads and two foundations. Psalm 1 gave the same choice in older words.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Jesus said the poor in spirit are blessed. What would it look like for you to come to God this week with empty hands?

The Sermon shows that the law reaches the heart. In light of that, how does the gospel, that Christ fulfilled the law for us, change the way you read these chapters?

Jesus invites us to call God “Our Father.” What difference does it make to your prayer life, your worries, and your sense of identity to know that?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to let your light shine so that others give him glory.

Thank Jesus for fulfilling the law in your place.

Thank him that you can call him Father.

DAY 575 · WEEK 83

Psalm 146

Praise the LORD who executes justice, the Beatitudes' God

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Psalm · 10 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 146. Read it as the Beatitudes in song form: a psalm about the God who blesses the poor, the hungry, and the oppressed. Notice the warning in verses 3 and 4 and the blessing in verse 5.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 146 is the first of the five closing Hallelujah psalms, and its theme matches the Sermon on the Mount you have just read. It is a praise song that centers on the character of God as the helper of the helpless. Jesus' opening words in the Sermon, "Blessed are the poor in spirit," sound much like this psalm's "Blessed is he whose help is the God of Jacob."

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Praise the LORD, O my soul!" (v. 1).
2. "I will praise the LORD as long as I live" (v. 2).
3. "Put not your trust in princes, in a son of man, in whom there is no salvation" (v. 3).
4. "When his breath departs, he returns to the earth; on that very day his plans perish" (v. 4).
5. "Blessed is he whose help is the God of Jacob, whose hope is in the LORD his God" (v. 5).
6. "Who executes justice for the oppressed, who gives food to the hungry" (v. 7).
7. "The LORD opens the eyes of the blind" (v. 8).
8. "The LORD will reign forever, your God, O Zion, to all generations" (v. 10).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm opens with the writer talking to his own soul: “Praise the LORD, O my soul!” He decides to praise for as long as he lives. Then comes a warning: do not trust princes, mortals, or any human leader as your final hope. Their breath leaves them, they return to dust, and their plans die with them. This is not cynicism about human government but realism. No leader can save you.

The alternative is the God of Jacob. He made heaven and earth and the sea, and he keeps faith forever. That last line is the foundation of everything. God’s faithfulness is not temporary. And what does this God do? He executes justice for the oppressed, gives food to the hungry, sets prisoners free, opens the eyes of the blind, lifts up those who are bowed down, loves the righteous, watches over strangers, and upholds the widow and fatherless.

Now read the Gospels in this light. When Jesus heals the blind, feeds the hungry, and welcomes the outsiders in the chapters ahead, he is doing what this psalm says the LORD does. John the Baptist will ask from prison whether Jesus is the one who is to come, and Jesus will answer by pointing to the blind who see and the poor who hear good news. The psalm tells us what to look for.

The psalm ends with “the LORD will reign forever.” Princes die. The king lives. Our hope rests there.

STEP 5

Connection

Matthew 11:2-6 shows Jesus answering John with the very works this psalm describes. Luke 4:18-19 has Jesus reading Isaiah 61 about good news to the poor, liberty to captives, and sight to the blind. Isaiah 2:22 says to stop regarding man, whose breath is in his nostrils. Jeremiah 17:5-8 contrasts trust in man with trust in the LORD. James 1:27 says pure religion is to visit orphans and widows. Revelation 11:15 declares that he shall reign forever and ever.

STEP 6

Application

Think about where you might be putting too much trust in a leader, a party, or a system. Re-center your hope on the LORD.

Choose one group named in verses 7 to 9 (the hungry, the oppressed, the foreigner, the widow, the orphan) and do one concrete thing to help.

Praise the LORD out loud today, with your whole soul, for something specific.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Praise God as long as you live, in your own words.

Confess where you trust in princes instead of him.

Thank him that he keeps faith forever and executes justice for the oppressed.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 83

“Come to me, all who labor and are heavy laden, and I will give you rest.”

MATTHEW 11:28

DAY 576 · WEEK 83

Psalm 147:1-11

He heals the brokenhearted

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Psalm · 11 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 147:1-11. You read all of Psalm 147 on Day 508 as a song for the rebuilt wall. Today read only the first eleven verses, and let them sit beside what Jesus does in the next chapters: healing the brokenhearted and binding up wounds.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The first half of Psalm 147 pairs two pictures: God the builder and gatherer, and God the healer. It also tells us what pleases him. Read these verses today with the Gospel of Matthew open in your mind, where the Messiah begins to touch lepers, lift the paralyzed, and call the weary to himself.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Praise the LORD! For it is good to sing praises to our God” (v. 1).
2. “The LORD builds up Jerusalem; he gathers the outcasts of Israel” (v. 2).
3. “He heals the brokenhearted and binds up their wounds” (v. 3).
4. “He determines the number of the stars; he gives to all of them their names” (v. 4).
5. “Great is our Lord, and abundant in power; his understanding is beyond measure” (v. 5).
6. “The LORD lifts up the humble; he casts the wicked to the ground” (v. 6).
7. “He gives to the beasts their food, and to the young ravens that cry” (v. 9).
8. “But the LORD takes pleasure in those who fear him, in those who hope in his steadfast love” (v. 11).

STEP 4

Interpretation

On Day 508, you heard this psalm at the dedication of the wall. Today, notice what stands out about verse 3: “He heals the brokenhearted and binds up their wounds.” Right after the gathering of the outcasts, the psalm turns to the personal. God does not only manage nations. He kneels to bandage individual hurts.

The next verse sets this beside the stars. The same God who counts and names the stars is the one who tends the brokenhearted. His power and his tenderness are not in competition. The Gospel of Matthew gives this a face. In the chapters you are about to read, Jesus touches a leper, raises a girl, and heals the sick. Matthew says that this fulfilled what Isaiah said: “He took our illnesses and bore our diseases.” The God of the stars came near to the broken.

Verses 10 and 11 tell us what God values. He does not delight in the strength of the horse or the legs of a man, which means military might and human physical power. He takes pleasure in those who fear him and hope in his steadfast love. God is not impressed by what we can do. He is moved by trust.

For a person who is hurting, this psalm is an invitation. You do not have to fix yourself before you come. The LORD heals the brokenhearted, and he does it because that is who he is.

STEP 5

Connection

Matthew 8:16-17 quotes Isaiah 53:4 about Jesus healing the sick. Matthew 11:28 calls the weary and burdened to come. Luke 4:18 says he has been sent to bind up the brokenhearted. Isaiah 61:1 is the source of that verse. Psalm 34:18 says the LORD is near to the brokenhearted. 2 Corinthians 1:3-4 calls God the Father of mercies and God of all comfort. Revelation 21:4 promises that he will wipe away every tear.

STEP 6

Application

Name one hurt you have been carrying. Bring it to the Lord in prayer without trying to tidy it first.

Look for someone brokenhearted near you and offer a quiet act of care: a call, a note, a meal.

Tonight, look at the stars and remember that the one who named them knows your name.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that he heals the brokenhearted and binds up their wounds.

Tell him what is broken in you.

Praise him for the stars he counts and names.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 83

“Come to me, all who labor and are heavy laden, and I will give you rest.”

MATTHEW 11:28

DAY 577 · WEEK 83

Matthew 8:1-9:38

Ten miracles, the King demonstrates the Kingdom's arrival

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Reading · 75 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Matthew 8:1-9:38. Matthew gathers ten miracles into two chapters: a leper, a centurion's servant, Peter's mother-in-law, a storm, two demon-possessed men, a paralytic, a dead girl, a woman with bleeding, two blind men, and a mute man. Read for what the miracles reveal about the King.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After the Sermon on the Mount, in which Jesus spoke with authority, Matthew shows Jesus acting with authority. The Sermon was the King's words, and these chapters are the King's works. Each miracle demonstrates that the kingdom of heaven has arrived, and each shows power over a different enemy: disease, nature, demons, sin, and death. Alongside the miracles, Matthew places the cost of following him.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Lord, if you will, you can make me clean" (8:2).
2. "Truly, I tell you, with no one in Israel have I found such faith" (8:10).
3. "This was to fulfill what was spoken by the prophet Isaiah: He took our illnesses and bore our diseases" (8:17).
4. "Foxes have holes, and birds of the air have nests, but the Son of Man has nowhere to lay his head" (8:20).
5. "What sort of man is this, that even winds and sea obey him?" (8:27).
6. "Take heart, my son; your sins are forgiven" (9:2).

7. “I desire mercy, and not sacrifice. For I came not to call the righteous, but sinners” (9:13).

8. “When he saw the crowds, he had compassion for them, because they were harassed and helpless, like sheep without a shepherd” (9:36).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The first miracle is a leper, the most unclean person in Israel. The law said that a leper must keep away and cry “Unclean!” Yet Jesus touches him, and instead of Jesus becoming unclean, the man becomes clean. Then comes a Roman centurion, a Gentile, who recognizes that Jesus needs only to say the word. Jesus is amazed at his faith and says that many will come from east and west to sit at table with Abraham. The kingdom is wider than Israel.

On the Sea of Galilee, a storm threatens to sink the boat while Jesus sleeps. He rebukes the wind and the waves, and there is a great calm. The disciples ask, “What sort of man is this?” Only God commands the sea (Psalm 107:29). He then sends demons into pigs and heals a paralyzed man. Here the order is striking: he first says “Your sins are forgiven,” and only then heals the body. The scribes call it blasphemy, and they are right that only God can forgive sins. Jesus proves his authority by healing.

Matthew himself, the tax collector, is called to follow. Jesus eats with tax collectors and sinners and says he is a physician for the sick. Then a ruler’s daughter is raised, a woman’s bleeding is healed, the blind see, and the mute speak.

The section ends with Jesus’ compassion. He sees the crowds as sheep without a shepherd and says the harvest is plentiful but the laborers are few. The miracles are not displays. They show the heart of the Messiah, who has come to rescue and to gather.

STEP 5

Connection

Leviticus 13 and 14 describe the laws for leprosy. Psalm 107:23-30 describes God calming the storm. Isaiah 53:4 is quoted in 8:17. Mark 2:1-12 gives a fuller account of the paralytic. Hosea 6:6 is quoted in 9:13. Ezekiel 34:5 describes shepherdless sheep. John 11:25: “I am the resurrection and the life.” Hebrews 4:15: we have a high priest who sympathizes with our weaknesses.

STEP 6

Application

Pray the leper’s prayer: “Lord, if you will, you can make me clean.” Name the specific thing you need cleansed or healed.

When storms come, remember that Jesus is in the boat. Say aloud, “Even the winds and sea obey him.”

Ask the Lord of the harvest to send workers, and ask whether you may be one.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell Jesus you believe, and ask him to help your unbelief.
- Ask him to make you clean where you need cleansing.
- Thank him for his power over storms, sin, and death.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 83

“Come to me, all who labor and are heavy laden, and I will give you rest.”

MATTHEW 11:28

DAY 578 · WEEK 83

Matthew 10:1-11:30

The Twelve sent; "Come to me, all who are weary"

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Reading · 79 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Matthew 10:1-11:30. Jesus sends out the Twelve and warns them about opposition. Then John the Baptist sends a question from prison, and Jesus ends the chapter with one of the most beloved invitations in the Bible. Read 11:28-30 slowly.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Having shown his compassion for the harassed crowds, Jesus calls twelve disciples and sends them to the lost sheep of Israel. The twelve apostles echo the twelve tribes: Jesus is gathering a renewed Israel. His instructions are honest about the cost. Then, in chapter 11, we see doubt and rejection, and Jesus responds with an invitation to the weary.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "And he called to him his twelve disciples and gave them authority over unclean spirits" (10:1).
2. "These twelve Jesus sent out, instructing them, Go nowhere among the Gentiles and enter no town of the Samaritans, but go rather to the lost sheep of the house of Israel" (10:5-6).
3. "Behold, I am sending you out as sheep in the midst of wolves, so be wise as serpents and innocent as doves" (10:16).
4. "Whoever loves father or mother more than me is not worthy of me" (10:37).
5. "Whoever finds his life will lose it, and whoever loses his life for my sake will find it" (10:39).
6. "Are you the one who is to come, or shall we look for another?" (11:3).

7. “Come to me, all who labor and are heavy laden, and I will give you rest” (11:28).
8. “For my yoke is easy, and my burden is light” (11:30).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The commission is clear and costly. The disciples are to proclaim the kingdom, heal, and cast out demons, depending on others for hospitality. Jesus warns them that they will be hated, brought before governors, and divided from their families. Yet he repeats, “Do not be afraid,” because the Father who cares for the sparrows cares for them. Those who acknowledge him before people, he will acknowledge before his Father.

His words about family are hard: loving him above father and mother. This is not a call to hate one’s family, but a statement that he must come first. And the paradox: finding your life means losing it for his sake.

Then John the Baptist, in prison, sends a question. He had announced the coming judge, and now he is in a cell, and Jesus is healing and eating with sinners. He wonders, “Are you the one?” It is a very human doubt. Jesus does not rebuke him. He points to the works: the blind see, the lame walk, lepers are cleansed, the poor have good news. And he says, “Blessed is the one who is not offended by me.” He then praises John as the greatest of the prophets.

Jesus condemns the cities that saw miracles and did not repent. And then, to the surprise of the reader, he prays and offers an invitation. “Come to me, all who labor and are heavy laden.” The yoke is the picture of a teacher’s way of life. The Pharisees’ yoke was heavy with rules. Jesus’ yoke is gentle. His rest is not a break from work but a relationship in which he carries the weight with us.

STEP 5

Connection

Jeremiah 31:25 promises to satisfy the weary soul. Exodus 33:14 records God saying, “My presence will go with you, and I will give you rest.” Acts 15:10 calls the burden of the law a yoke that neither we nor our fathers could bear. Hebrews 4:9-11 speaks of a Sabbath rest for the people of God. Luke 14:26-33 teaches the cost of discipleship. Philippians 3:7-8 shows Paul counting all things as loss for Christ. 1 John 5:3: his commandments are not burdensome.

STEP 6

Application

If you are weary today, stop and take Jesus’ invitation personally. Tell him specifically what is heavy.

Think of a person who is doubting. Respond like Jesus did to John: patiently, with evidence of God's goodness.

Ask what it means to take his yoke and learn from him. What practice could you begin?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Come to Jesus weary and burdened, and tell him what weighs on you.
- Ask him to teach you, for he is gentle and lowly in heart.
- Take his yoke, and tell him what that means.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 83

"Come to me, all who labor and are heavy laden, and I will give you rest."

MATTHEW 11:28

DAY 579 · WEEK 83

Matthew 12:1-13:23

Sabbath controversies; Beelzebul; the Sower

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Reading · 82 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Matthew 12:1-13:23. Jesus is Lord of the Sabbath, the Pharisees accuse him of working by Satan's power, and he tells the first parables. Pay close attention to the parable of the sower and Jesus' explanation.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Opposition has been building, and in chapter 12 it becomes open conflict. The Pharisees object to Jesus' disciples picking grain on the Sabbath and to his healing on the Sabbath. They then accuse him of casting out demons by Beelzebul. Jesus responds with arguments from Scripture and warnings. In chapter 13, he begins teaching in parables, stories that reveal the kingdom to those with ears to hear and conceal it from those who harden their hearts.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "For the Son of Man is lord of the Sabbath" (12:8).
2. "I desire mercy, and not sacrifice" (12:7).
3. "Behold, my servant whom I have chosen, my beloved with whom my soul is well pleased" (12:18).
4. "If I cast out demons by the Spirit of God, then the kingdom of God has come upon you" (12:28).
5. "Whoever is not with me is against me" (12:30).
6. "For something greater than Solomon is here" (12:42).
7. "And he told them many things in parables, saying, A sower went out to sow" (13:3).

8 “As for what was sown on good soil, this is the one who hears the word and understands it. He indeed bears fruit” (13:23).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The Sabbath conflicts reveal a clash between two ways of reading God’s law. The Pharisees saw rules to protect. Jesus saw mercy to practice. He cites David, who ate the consecrated bread when hungry, and the priests who work in the temple on the Sabbath. Then he says, “Something greater than the temple is here,” and that the Son of Man is lord of the Sabbath. This is a startling claim: he is the one who gave the Sabbath and the one to whom the Sabbath points.

Matthew quotes Isaiah’s servant song, showing a gentle servant who will not break a bruised reed. Then when Jesus casts out a demon, the Pharisees say he does it by the prince of demons. Jesus answers: a kingdom divided against itself cannot stand. If he casts out demons by the Spirit of God, then the kingdom has arrived. The unforgivable sin, blasphemy against the Spirit, is attributing the Spirit’s work to Satan, persistently and with a hardened heart. People who seek forgiveness have not committed it.

The parable of the sower begins chapter 13. A farmer scatters seed on four kinds of soil: the path, rocky ground, thorns, and good soil. The seed is the same. The difference is in the hearers. Some do not understand and the evil one snatches the word. Some receive it with joy but have no root. Some are choked by worries and wealth. And some hear, understand, and bear fruit. Jesus explains that parables reveal truth to those who are open and conceal it from those who are not.

The point is for you to ask which soil you are. The remedy for a hard heart is not to try harder but to ask the Sower to work on the soil.

STEP 5

Connection

Exodus 20:8-11 gives the Sabbath command. Hosea 6:6 is quoted in 12:7. Isaiah 42:1-4 is quoted in 12:18-21. Mark 3:28-30 gives a parallel to the warning about the Spirit. Isaiah 6:9-10 is quoted in 13:14-15 about hardened hearts. Hebrews 4:1-11 teaches Sabbath rest fulfilled in Christ. Colossians 2:16-17 says the Sabbath was a shadow of what was to come. James 1:21 says to receive with meekness the implanted word.

STEP 6

Application

Honestly ask which soil describes you right now. If the thorns of worry or wealth are choking the word, name them.

Remember that Jesus is Lord of the Sabbath. Receive rest as a gift from him, not a rule to earn.

Pray for someone close to you who seems hard or unresponsive to the gospel.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus for being Lord of the Sabbath.
- Ask him to break up hard ground in your heart.
- Ask him to help you bear fruit.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 83

“Come to me, all who labor and are heavy laden, and I will give you rest.”

MATTHEW 11:28

DAY 580 · WEEK 83

Psalm 78:1-16

He commanded our fathers to teach their children

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Psalm · 16 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 78:1-16. This psalm begins with a teacher's voice and a plan to teach the next generation. Notice that the first verse is quoted in Matthew 13:35 as a reason Jesus spoke in parables.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 78 is a long historical poem, and its first sixteen verses introduce its purpose. Asaph invites the people to listen to a "parable," a teaching that recounts the exodus and the wilderness. Matthew applies the psalm's opening line to Jesus: "I will open my mouth in parables; I will utter what has been hidden since the foundation of the world." Jesus was telling the story of God's people in a new way.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Give ear, O my people, to my teaching; incline your ears to the words of my mouth!" (v. 1).
2. "I will open my mouth in a parable; I will utter dark sayings from of old" (v. 2).
3. "We will not hide them from their children, but tell to the coming generation the glorious deeds of the LORD" (v. 4).
4. "He established a testimony in Jacob and appointed a law in Israel" (v. 5).
5. "That the next generation might know them, the children yet unborn" (v. 6).
6. "So that they should set their hope in God and not forget the works of God" (v. 7).
7. "The Ephraimites, armed with bows, turned back on the day of battle" (v. 9).

8 “He divided the sea and let them pass through it, and made the waters stand like a heap” (v. 13).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm is a lesson in how faith is passed on. The speaker says that what we have heard and known, and what our fathers told us, we will not hide from our children. God commanded the fathers to teach their children, so that each generation would know and set hope in God, and not be like their stubborn ancestors. The goal is not information alone, but hope, remembrance, and obedience.

Then the psalm gives a negative example: the Ephraimites, who were armed and yet turned back in battle because they “did not keep God’s covenant.” They forgot his works. The rest of the psalm, which you will read later, is a catalog of Israel’s forgetfulness.

The first verses of the history begin with the exodus. God divided the sea, led them with a cloud by day and fire by night, and split rocks in the wilderness to give them water “abundantly as the deep.” These are wonders that should have inspired lasting trust.

Matthew quotes the psalm’s opening in 13:35 to explain Jesus’ parables. The parable of the Sower came right before. Jesus was now doing what Asaph said: opening his mouth in parables and uttering what had been hidden. And the content was the story of Israel retold. The King was both the teacher and the fulfillment of the story.

For parents, teachers, and the children’s ministry, this psalm is a charter. The purpose of teaching is that the next generation will “set their hope in God.” Tell the stories. Do not hide them.

STEP 5

Connection

Matthew 13:34-35 quotes verse 2 as fulfilled in Jesus. Deuteronomy 6:6-7 commands teaching the words of God to your children. Exodus 14 and 17 are the events recalled. Proverbs 22:6 says to train up a child in the way he should go. 2 Timothy 1:5 and 3:14-15 describe faith passed through grandmother and mother. Ephesians 6:4 tells fathers to bring up their children in the discipline and instruction of the Lord. Joel 1:3: tell your children of it.

STEP 6

Application

Tell one younger person, a child, a grandchild, a student, or a new believer, a story of what God has done.

Write down three works of God in your own life, so you will not forget them.

If you serve with children, pray for the next generation to set their hope in God.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to help you pass on what you have heard and known.

Confess where you hide his deeds from the next generation.

Thank him for those who taught you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 83

“Come to me, all who labor and are heavy laden, and I will give you rest.”

MATTHEW 11:28

DAY 581 · WEEK 83

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Matthew 11:28 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"Come to me, all who labor and are heavy laden, and I will give you rest."

MATTHEW 11:28

REST

Meditation

This invitation comes right after Jesus has condemned cities that would not repent, and right after he has said that the Father has revealed these things to little children. It is addressed to people who know they are tired.

"Come to me." Jesus does not say, "Come to a system," or "Come to my teaching." He says, "Come to me." Rest is found in a person. The invitation is personal, direct, and present. You are not asked to improve first.

"All who labor and are heavy laden." "Labor" means to be worn out from toil, and "heavy laden" means loaded down. It includes the weariness of trying to earn God's favor, the weight of guilt, the burden of grief, and the sheer tiredness of life in a fallen world. The invitation is for "all." No one is excluded.

“And I will give you rest.” The word “give” is crucial. Rest is a gift. It is not wages. Jesus gives soul rest: peace with God, relief from the need to prove ourselves, and a settled place in him. In the next verses, he says that his yoke is easy and his burden light.

This verse is for the weary Christian as well as the seeker. Keep it near. When you are exhausted by life or by trying to be good enough, hear him say it to you again: Come.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you followed Jesus through the Sermon’s conclusion and into his works. You learned from Psalm 1 and Matthew 7 that there are two roads and two foundations. In Psalms 146 and 147, you praised the God who helps the helpless and heals the brokenhearted, and in Matthew 8 and 9 you saw Jesus do exactly that: cleansing a leper, calming a storm, forgiving a paralytic, and raising a girl. You saw him send out the Twelve, answer John’s doubt with works, and invite the weary to come to him. You watched the opposition grow as he declared himself Lord of the Sabbath, and you heard the parable of the sower. Psalm 78 reminded you to pass the stories of God’s deeds to the next generation.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Jesus said, “Come to me, all who labor and are heavy laden.” What weights are you carrying that you have not yet brought to him?

Jesus forgave the paralytic’s sins before healing his body. Why do you think he started there, and what does that say about our deepest need?

The parable of the sower asks what kind of soil we are. What is one practical way you can prepare your heart to receive and keep the word this week?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Come to Jesus tired and burdened, and thank him for the rest he gives.

Ask him to heal what is broken.

Ask him to forgive what needs forgiving.

DAY 582 · WEEK 84

Psalm 25

Make me to know your ways, O LORD

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Psalm · 22 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 25. This is a prayer of David, an acrostic, in which he asks God to teach him his ways. Read it as a disciple's prayer, the prayer of someone who wants to learn from the Master.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 25 is a prayer of someone in trouble, surrounded by enemies and burdened by guilt, who turns to God for guidance and forgiveness. It is arranged as an acrostic, with each line starting with the next Hebrew letter. Coming after Jesus' call to "learn from me," it works as a prayer of discipleship: "Make me to know your ways, O LORD; teach me your paths."

STEP 3

Observation

1. "To you, O LORD, I lift up my soul" (v. 1).
2. "Make me to know your ways, O LORD; teach me your paths" (v. 4).
3. "Lead me in your truth and teach me, for you are the God of my salvation" (v. 5).
4. "Remember not the sins of my youth or my transgressions; according to your steadfast love remember me" (v. 7).
5. "Good and upright is the LORD; therefore he instructs sinners in the way" (v. 8).
6. "He leads the humble in what is right, and teaches the humble his way" (v. 9).
7. "The friendship of the LORD is for those who fear him, and he makes known to them his covenant" (v. 14).
8. "Turn to me and be gracious to me, for I am lonely and afflicted" (v. 16).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with trust: “To you, I lift up my soul.” The soul is lifted like a hand, in dependence. The psalmist asks not to be put to shame and says that those who wait on the LORD will not be.

Then comes the core request, repeated in several forms: show me your ways, teach me your paths, lead me in your truth. Notice the humility. David the king asks to be taught. He knows that guidance is not automatic, and that he needs God to show him the way. And the ground of his hope is not his own merit. He says, “You are the God of my salvation.”

He asks God to forget the sins of his youth and remember him according to steadfast love. This is the language of grace. David knows his past. He asks to be dealt with by God’s mercy, not by his record. “For your name’s sake, O LORD, pardon my guilt, for it is great.” He does not minimize his sin.

The central insight is verse 8: “Good and upright is the LORD; therefore he instructs sinners in the way.” God teaches sinners. The qualification for a student is not being good already but being humble. “He leads the humble in what is right.”

Verse 14 is a gem: “The friendship of the LORD is for those who fear him.” The word for friendship can be “intimacy” or “confidential counsel.” God shares his secrets with those who revere him. The psalm ends with a plea for rescue and for the redemption of Israel from all his troubles. It is a model for a new believer who wants to learn.

STEP 5

Connection

Matthew 11:29: “Learn from me, for I am gentle and lowly in heart.” John 15:15: “I have called you friends.” Proverbs 3:5-6 says to trust in the LORD and he will make your paths straight. James 1:5 promises wisdom to those who ask. Psalm 119:105 says his word is a lamp to our feet. Isaiah 30:21 promises a voice saying, “This is the way, walk in it.” Romans 8:1: there is therefore now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus.

STEP 6

Application

Make verses 4 and 5 your daily morning prayer for a week.

Bring a specific decision to God and ask him to show you the way. Listen through his word.

Confess one sin from your past that still weighs on you, and trust his steadfast love to remember you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Lift up your soul to God, and tell him what you want to know of his ways.
- Ask him to lead you in his truth.
- Ask him not to remember the sins of your youth.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 84

"This is my beloved Son, with whom I am well pleased; listen to him."

MATTHEW 17:5

DAY 583 · WEEK 84

Matthew 13:24-14:36

Kingdom parables; John beheaded; the feeding

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Reading · 64 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Matthew 13:24-14:36. Jesus tells more parables of the kingdom, is rejected in Nazareth, and hears of John's death. Then he feeds five thousand and walks on the sea. Notice Peter in the boat.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The parables of Matthew 13 explain what the kingdom is like now that the King is here. It is not what many expected, an immediate military takeover. It begins small, grows slowly, and exists alongside evil until the end. Then the narrative moves quickly: Jesus is rejected at home, John the Baptist is killed, and the crowds are fed. In each scene, the identity of Jesus is the question.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The kingdom of heaven is like a grain of mustard seed that a man took and sowed in his field" (13:31).
2. "The kingdom of heaven is like leaven that a woman took and hid in three measures of flour" (13:33).
3. "The kingdom of heaven is like treasure hidden in a field, which a man found and covered up. Then in his joy he goes and sells all that he has and buys that field" (13:44).
4. "Is not this the carpenter's son?" (13:55).
5. "And he did not do many mighty works there, because of their unbelief" (13:58).
6. "They took up his body and buried it, and they went and told Jesus" (14:12).
7. "You give them something to eat" (14:16).

8 “Take heart; it is I. Do not be afraid” (14:27).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The parables of the weeds, mustard seed, and leaven teach that the kingdom starts small and spreads quietly, and that good and evil grow together until the harvest. The wheat and the weeds will be separated at the end, and not before. This protects us from two errors: trying to purify the church by force, and thinking that evil has won.

The treasure and the pearl show the worth of the kingdom. A man finds treasure and sells everything for joy. This is not grudging sacrifice but delighted exchange. Following Jesus costs everything, and it is worth it.

Then comes rejection. In his hometown, the people take offense at him: “Is not this the carpenter’s son?” Familiarity breeds contempt. Matthew says he did not do many works there because of unbelief.

When Jesus hears about John’s death, he withdraws to a quiet place, but the crowds follow. He has compassion and heals them. In the evening, the disciples want to send the people away. Jesus says, “You give them something to eat.” With five loaves and two fish, he feeds five thousand men, besides women and children, with twelve baskets left over. It echoes the manna in the wilderness and anticipates the Lord’s Supper.

Then Jesus sends the disciples ahead in the boat and goes up to pray. In the storm he comes walking on the sea, which only God does (Job 9:8). Peter steps out, walks, sees the wind, and begins to sink. “Lord, save me.” Jesus catches him. The disciples worship: “Truly you are the Son of God.”

STEP 5

Connection

Daniel 2:34-35 and 44-45 compare the kingdom to a stone that becomes a mountain. Ezekiel 17:22-24 uses the image of a tree where birds nest. Philippians 3:7-8 shows Paul counting all things as loss for Christ. Exodus 16 describes manna in the wilderness. Job 9:8 says God alone treads on the waves of the sea. Psalm 77:19 says God’s way was through the sea. John 6:35: “I am the bread of life.” Hebrews 12:2 says to look to Jesus.

STEP 6

Application

Think of the kingdom like treasure. Is there something you are holding too tightly that you would be glad to exchange for it?

When Jesus says, “You give them something to eat,” ask what small thing you can offer. He can multiply it.

When you start to sink, say Peter’s prayer: “Lord, save me.”

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell Jesus what you are holding too tightly.
- Ask him to teach you to treasure the kingdom above all.
- Thank him for feeding you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 84

“This is my beloved Son, with whom I am well pleased; listen to him.”

MATTHEW 17:5

DAY 584 · WEEK 84

Matthew 15:1-16:28

Defilement; Peter's confession; the cross predicted

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Reading · 72 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Matthew 15:1-16:28. Jesus teaches what really defiles a person, heals a Gentile woman's daughter, feeds four thousand, and asks the disciples who they say he is. Peter's confession is the center of the Gospel. Read 16:13-28 slowly.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The conflict with the Pharisees continues. Jesus turns away from the hand-washing traditions to the heart. He then travels into Gentile territory, where he meets a woman of great faith. Then, in the region of Caesarea Philippi, he asks the question that changes everything. From that point on, Matthew says, Jesus begins to show the disciples that he must go to Jerusalem and suffer.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "This people honors me with their lips, but their heart is far from me" (15:8).
2. "What comes out of the mouth proceeds from the heart, and this defiles a person" (15:18).
3. "Woman, great is your faith! Be it done for you as you desire" (15:28).
4. "Beware of the leaven of the Pharisees and Sadducees" (16:6).
5. "Who do you say that I am?" (16:15).
6. "You are the Christ, the Son of the living God" (16:16).
7. "And I tell you, you are Peter, and on this rock I will build my church, and the gates of hell shall not prevail against it" (16:18).

8 “If anyone would come after me, let him deny himself and take up his cross and follow me” (16:24).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Jesus says that defilement is not about unwashed hands or food. It is about the heart. Evil thoughts, murder, adultery, theft, and slander all come from within. This was shocking to people who defined holiness by external rules. The real problem is inside, and only God can change it.

The Canaanite woman is a surprising example of faith. She is a Gentile who cries out to the Son of David. Jesus tests her, and she persists with humility: even dogs eat the crumbs from the table. Jesus commends her: “Great is your faith!” A foreigner understands what the leaders of Israel do not.

Then comes the pivot. Jesus asks who people say he is, and then, “Who do you say that I am?” Peter answers, “You are the Christ, the Son of the living God.” This is the memory verse of the unit. Christ means the Messiah, the anointed king. Jesus says that this was revealed to Peter by the Father. On this confession, Jesus will build his church, and not even death’s gates will stand against it. Whether “the rock” refers to Peter, to his confession, or both, the church rests on the truth that Jesus is the Christ.

But immediately Jesus begins to explain that the Christ must suffer, be killed, and be raised. Peter rebukes him, and Jesus calls him Satan, a stumbling block, for setting his mind on the things of man. Then the call goes out to all: deny yourself, take up your cross, and follow. “Whoever loses his life for my sake will find it.” The Christ is a crucified Christ, and his followers walk the same road.

STEP 5

Connection

Isaiah 29:13 is quoted in 15:8. Mark 7:14-23 adds that Jesus declared all foods clean. Romans 10:9 says if you confess with your mouth that Jesus is Lord and believe in your heart that God raised him, you will be saved. Ephesians 2:20 says the household of God is built on the foundation of the apostles and prophets, Christ Jesus himself being the cornerstone. Galatians 2:20: “I have been crucified with Christ.” Luke 9:23 adds “daily.” Hebrews 12:2.

STEP 6

Application

Answer Jesus’ question in your own words: “Who do you say that I am?” Write it down.

Ask where your heart is far from God while your lips are near. Bring that to him.

Think about what taking up your cross looks like in your current season.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess with Peter who you believe Jesus is.
- Ask him to cleanse your heart from the inside.
- Ask him to teach you what it means to take up your cross.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 84

"This is my beloved Son, with whom I am well pleased; listen to him."

MATTHEW 17:5

DAY 585 · WEEK 84

Matthew 17:1-18:35

The Transfiguration; greatness and forgiveness

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Reading · 65 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Matthew 17:1-18:35. Jesus is transfigured on the mountain, the Father speaks, and then Jesus teaches about greatness, discipline, and forgiveness. Read the Transfiguration in light of the end of chapter 16.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Six days after Peter's confession and Jesus' first prediction of his death, Jesus takes Peter, James, and John up a high mountain. There his appearance changes, and Moses and Elijah, the law and the prophets, appear and speak with him. It is a glimpse of his glory, given to strengthen the disciples for the road to the cross. Then, in chapter 18, Jesus gives teaching on life in the community of the kingdom.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "And he was transfigured before them, and his face shone like the sun, and his clothes became white as light" (17:2).
2. "And behold, there appeared to them Moses and Elijah, talking with him" (17:3).
3. "This is my beloved Son, with whom I am well pleased; listen to him" (17:5).
4. "Jesus came and touched them, saying, Rise, and have no fear" (17:7).
5. "If you have faith like a grain of mustard seed, you will say to this mountain, Move from here to there, and it will move" (17:20).
6. "Unless you turn and become like children, you will never enter the kingdom of heaven" (18:3).
7. "For where two or three are gathered in my name, there am I among them" (18:20).

8 “I do not say to you seven times, but seventy-seven times” (18:22).

STEP 4

Interpretation

On the mountain, the disciples see the glory that is usually hidden. Jesus shines like the sun, and Moses and Elijah, who both met God on a mountain, speak with him. Luke tells us they spoke of his “departure,” literally his exodus, which he was about to accomplish at Jerusalem. The law and the prophets bear witness to Jesus and his coming death.

Peter wants to build three tents, but a cloud covers them, and the Father says almost the same words as at the baptism, with an addition: “Listen to him.” Moses and Elijah fade away. Jesus alone remains. The Law and the Prophets point to him, and now the voice of heaven says that he is the one to hear. When they look up, they see only Jesus.

Coming down, they find the disciples failing to heal a boy, and Jesus tells them that even a small faith moves mountains. He again predicts his death and resurrection.

In chapter 18, Jesus teaches that greatness in the kingdom belongs to the humble like children. He warns about causing little ones to stumble and tells the story of the lost sheep: the Father does not want any to perish. He then gives a process for restoring a sinning brother, and promises his presence where two or three gather in his name.

Peter asks how often to forgive, and Jesus says seventy-seven times. The parable of the unforgiving servant follows, a man forgiven a huge debt who refuses to forgive a small one. The lesson is that those who have been forgiven much must forgive. The mercy we have received is the pattern and power for the mercy we give.

STEP 5

Connection

Exodus 34:29-35 shows Moses’ face shining. 2 Peter 1:16-18 recalls Peter’s witness of this event. Luke 9:31 mentions the exodus Jesus would accomplish. Deuteronomy 18:15 promises a prophet like Moses to whom Israel should listen. Hebrews 1:1-2 says God has spoken to us by his Son. Colossians 3:13: “As the Lord has forgiven you, so you also must forgive.” Ephesians 4:32. Revelation 1:12-18.

STEP 6

Application

Listen to Jesus this week. Read a Gospel passage slowly, with the sense that the Father is saying, “Listen to him.”

Think of someone who has wronged you. Consider the size of your own forgiven debt, and take a step toward forgiveness.

Seek out a small child or a humble person and learn something about trust.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to help you listen to his beloved Son.
- Thank him for showing his glory to strengthen you.
- Ask him to make you someone who forgives.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 84

"This is my beloved Son, with whom I am well pleased; listen to him."

MATTHEW 17:5

DAY 586 · WEEK 84

Psalm 2

You are my Son, the voice at the Transfiguration

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Psalm · 12 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 2. The Father's voice at the baptism and the Transfiguration drew on this psalm: "You are my Son." Read it as the coronation of the Messiah, and notice the warning and the invitation at the end.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 2 is a royal psalm, probably first used at the crowning of a king in the line of David. It has four parts: the nations plot (vv. 1-3), God laughs from heaven (vv. 4-6), the king declares God's decree (vv. 7-9), and the nations are warned to submit (vv. 10-12). The New Testament sees its full meaning in Jesus. After the Transfiguration, it gives the background to the Father's words.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Why do the nations rage and the peoples plot in vain?" (v. 1).
2. "The kings of the earth set themselves, and the rulers take counsel together, against the LORD and against his Anointed" (v. 2).
3. "He who sits in the heavens laughs; the Lord holds them in derision" (v. 4).
4. "As for me, I have set my King on Zion, my holy hill" (v. 6).
5. "You are my Son; today I have begotten you" (v. 7).
6. "Ask of me, and I will make the nations your heritage, and the ends of the earth your possession" (v. 8).
7. "Now therefore, O kings, be wise; be warned, O rulers of the earth" (v. 10).
8. "Blessed are all who take refuge in him" (v. 12).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with a question that every generation has asked: why do the nations rage against God? Rulers conspire against the LORD and his Anointed. They want to throw off his rule: “Let us burst their bonds apart.” The scene is of human defiance.

Heaven’s reaction is surprising. God laughs. It is not a cheerful laugh but the scorn of one whose throne is not threatened. Human rebellion is real, but it does not unseat him. He has already installed his king on Zion.

Then the king speaks. He announces the decree: “You are my Son; today I have begotten you.” In the ancient world, a king was adopted as God’s son on the day of his coronation. For David’s line, this was a title and a covenant. For Jesus, it is more. At his baptism and Transfiguration, the Father spoke these words about him, and Hebrews 1:5 applies it to his resurrection and enthronement. He is the Son in a unique sense.

The Son is promised the nations as his inheritance, and he will rule them with a rod of iron. The psalm does not hide that the Messiah’s reign includes judgment on those who persist in rebellion.

Yet the psalm ends with an invitation. Kings are told to be wise, to serve the LORD with fear, and to “kiss the Son,” a gesture of homage, “lest he be angry.” The final line is a beatitude: “Blessed are all who take refuge in him.” The same Son who will judge is the refuge for all who come to him. The Sermon began with “Blessed”; Psalm 1 began with “Blessed”; Psalm 2 ends with “Blessed.” The choice is to resist him or take refuge in him.

STEP 5

Connection

Acts 4:25-28 quotes this psalm about the plot against Jesus. Acts 13:33 applies verse 7 to the resurrection. Hebrews 1:5 and 5:5 quote verse 7. Revelation 2:26-27 and 19:15 allude to the iron rod. Matthew 3:17 and 17:5 echo verse 7. Philippians 2:9-11 says every knee will bow. Romans 1:4 says Jesus was declared to be the Son of God in power by his resurrection from the dead.

STEP 6

Application

Ask whether any part of your life is in rebellion against his rule. Surrender it.

When the news feels chaotic and the nations rage, remember that God has set his King on Zion.

Take refuge in the Son. Name a fear or burden, and say aloud, “I take refuge in him.”

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God what rage and plotting you see in the world.
- Thank him for the Son he has enthroned.
- Take refuge in him, and say so.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 84

"This is my beloved Son, with whom I am well pleased; listen to him."

MATTHEW 17:5

DAY 587 · WEEK 84

Psalm 110

The LORD says to my Lord, Melchizedek and priesthood

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Psalm · 7 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 110. This is the Old Testament psalm quoted most often in the New Testament. Jesus used it in Matthew 22 to ask the Pharisees a question they could not answer. Read it as the portrait of a king who is also a priest.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 110 is a short psalm of David, only seven verses. It records a conversation within God: the LORD speaks to David's Lord. It describes a king who sits at God's right hand and a priest forever in the order of Melchizedek. Today you read it after Psalm 2 and the Transfiguration, and just before Jesus uses it in the temple.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The LORD says to my Lord: Sit at my right hand, until I make your enemies your footstool" (v. 1).
2. "The LORD sends forth from Zion your mighty scepter. Rule in the midst of your enemies!" (v. 2).
3. "Your people will offer themselves freely on the day of your power" (v. 3).
4. "The LORD has sworn and will not change his mind: You are a priest forever after the order of Melchizedek" (v. 4).
5. "The Lord is at your right hand; he will shatter kings on the day of his wrath" (v. 5).
6. "He will execute judgment among the nations" (v. 6).
7. "He will drink from the brook by the way; therefore he will lift up his head" (v. 7).

8 “He will execute judgment among the nations, filling them with corpses; he will shatter chiefs over the wide earth” (v. 6).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The first verse is a puzzle. David, the king, calls someone “my Lord.” The LORD (Yahweh) speaks to this other Lord and invites him to sit at his right hand, the place of highest honor and authority. Who is this? A king calls no one lord except God. Yet this figure is also David’s descendant. In Matthew 22:41-46, Jesus asks the Pharisees exactly this: if the Christ is David’s son, how does David call him Lord? They have no answer. The answer is that the Messiah is both David’s son and David’s Lord, fully human and fully divine.

The psalm describes his reign. He rules from Zion in the midst of his enemies. His people come willingly, “in holy garments,” ready to serve. His enemies become his footstool.

Then verse 4 gives the second puzzle: this king is also a priest forever. In Israel, kings came from Judah and priests from Levi, and the two offices were kept apart. But Melchizedek was both king of Salem and priest of God Most High, who blessed Abraham in Genesis 14. The psalm says the Messiah will be a priest like him, not by genealogy, but by God’s oath. And it is an oath God will not change.

Hebrews builds its whole argument on this verse. Jesus is the priest who offered himself once for all, and is now seated at God’s right hand, where he intercedes for us. He is not standing like the Old Testament priests, whose work was never done. He sits because his work is finished.

The psalm ends with the king refreshed and lifting up his head, a picture of victory. After the Transfiguration and before the passion week, this psalm sets the course: the Son will suffer, be raised, and reign.

STEP 5

Connection

Matthew 22:41-46 records Jesus’ question about this psalm. Acts 2:33-36 applies it to the ascension. Hebrews 5:5-10, 7:1-28, and 10:11-14 explain Melchizedek and Christ’s priesthood. Genesis 14:18-20 introduces Melchizedek. Romans 8:34: Christ Jesus is at the right hand of God, interceding for us. 1 Corinthians 15:25 says he must reign until he has put all his enemies under his feet. Colossians 3:1.

STEP 6

Application

Remember today that Jesus is seated at the Father’s right hand, in authority, praying for you.

When you feel guilty, remember that your priest is the perfect one who has offered the final sacrifice.

Offer yourself willingly to his service today, as the psalm says his people do.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Worship Jesus as David's son and David's Lord.
- Thank him that he is a priest forever.
- Ask him to make his enemies his footstool in your life too.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 84

"This is my beloved Son, with whom I am well pleased; listen to him."

MATTHEW 17:5

DAY 588 · WEEK 84

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Matthew 17:5 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"This is my beloved Son, with whom I am well pleased; listen to him."

MATTHEW 17:5

REST

Meditation

The Father spoke these words from a bright cloud on the mountain. Peter had just suggested building three tents, one for Jesus, one for Moses, and one for Elijah. The Father interrupted him.

"This is my beloved Son." The Father identifies Jesus. He is not a prophet among prophets or a teacher among teachers. He is the Son, and the Father loves him. This is the same voice that spoke at the baptism, now speaking to the disciples directly.

"With whom I am well pleased." The Father delights in the Son. Jesus' obedience, his life, and his mission please the Father. And because we are in Christ, the Father's delight in the Son reaches us.

"Listen to him." This is the addition, and it is a command. Moses and Elijah, the law and the prophets, were great. But now the final word has come in the Son. Hebrews 1:1-2 says that God spoke in many ways long ago by the prophets, but in these last days he has spoken to us

by his Son. We are not to listen to Jesus alongside other equal voices. We are to listen to him above all.

What does it mean to listen to him? Not just to hear, but to obey. The disciples fell on their faces in fear, and Jesus came and touched them and said, “Rise, and have no fear.” The one we are told to listen to is gentle. When you read the Gospels this week, imagine the Father saying, “Listen to him.”

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you moved from the quiet parables to the great confession. You heard Jesus teach that the kingdom starts small, like a mustard seed, and is worth more than all you own. You watched him feed five thousand and walk on the sea, and you saw Peter step out and sink. You read that defilement comes from the heart, that a Gentile woman showed great faith, and that Peter confessed, “You are the Christ, the Son of the living God.” You saw Jesus begin to speak of the cross and call his followers to take up theirs. On the mountain you saw him transfigured, and heard the Father say, “Listen to him.” You then learned about humility, correction, and forgiveness. The psalms framed it: Psalm 25 asked to be taught, Psalm 2 crowned the Son, and Psalm 110 showed a king and priest at God’s right hand.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Peter confessed that Jesus is the Christ, and almost immediately rebuked him for talking about the cross. Where are you tempted to want a Jesus without a cross?

The Father said, “Listen to him.” What does listening to Jesus look like in your daily routine?

Jesus told Peter to forgive seventy-seven times. Whom do you find hardest to forgive, and how does knowing how much you have been forgiven change that?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to help you listen to his beloved Son and obey.

Thank him for the glory shown and the cross carried.

Rest in him.

DAY 589 · WEEK 85

Matthew 19:1-20:34

Marriage, children, wealth; servant leadership

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Reading · 63 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Matthew 19:1-20:34. Jesus teaches on marriage, children, and wealth, then tells the parable of the workers in the vineyard. He predicts his death a third time and heals two blind men. Read 20:25-28 slowly.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Jesus has left Galilee and is traveling toward Jerusalem. Along the road, he teaches about the shape of kingdom life: faithfulness in marriage, welcome for the vulnerable, freedom from the grip of money, and a radical idea of greatness. The shadow of the cross grows longer, and the disciples still do not understand.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “What therefore God has joined together, let not man separate” (19:6).
2. “Let the little children come to me and do not hinder them, for to such belongs the kingdom of heaven” (19:14).
3. “If you would be perfect, go, sell what you possess and give to the poor, and you will have treasure in heaven; and come, follow me” (19:21).
4. “It is easier for a camel to go through the eye of a needle than for a rich person to enter the kingdom of God” (19:24).
5. “With man this is impossible, but with God all things are possible” (19:26).
6. “But many who are first will be last, and the last first” (19:30).
7. “Are you envious because I am generous?” (20:15).

8 “Whoever would be great among you must be your servant… even as the Son of Man came not to be served but to serve, and to give his life as a ransom for many” (20:26-28).

STEP 4

Interpretation

On marriage, Jesus goes back to Genesis. God made them male and female, and the two become one flesh. Divorce was permitted by Moses because of hardness of hearts, but it was not the original design. Jesus takes marriage seriously, as a covenant joined by God.

When parents bring children for blessing, the disciples try to send them away. Jesus rebukes them. The kingdom belongs to those who receive it with a child’s openness and dependence.

The rich young man is a tragic scene. He has kept the commandments, and he asks what he still lacks. Jesus lovingly tests his heart: sell what you have, give to the poor, and follow me. The man goes away sorrowful, for he had great wealth. His possessions had hold of him. Jesus tells the disciples how hard it is for the rich to enter the kingdom, and when they ask who can be saved, he says, “With man this is impossible, but with God all things are possible.” Salvation is a gift of God’s power, not something we manage. Peter asks what the disciples will get, and Jesus promises great reward, and then warns that the first will be last.

The vineyard parable makes the point. Workers hired at the last hour receive the same pay as those who worked all day. The owner says, “Are you envious because I am generous?” God’s grace is not wages. It is a gift.

Then comes the third prediction of death, and immediately two disciples ask for the best seats. Jesus redefines greatness. In the world, leaders lord it over others. In the kingdom, the great one serves. And he gives himself as the model: the Son of Man came to give his life as a ransom for many. This is the key to the Gospel.

STEP 5

Connection

Genesis 1:27 and 2:24 are quoted in 19:4-5. Mark 10:17-31 gives a parallel to the rich young ruler. Philippians 2:5-8 describes the servant-hearted mind of Christ. 1 Timothy 6:17-19 teaches the rich to be generous. Isaiah 53:10-12 describes the suffering servant who bears the sin of many. 1 Peter 1:18-19 says we were ransomed by the precious blood of Christ. Ephesians 2:8-9 says salvation is a gift of God, not a result of works.

STEP 6

Application

Ask what you would find hardest to give up if Jesus asked. Pray about it honestly.

Welcome a child or a person of low status this week in a way that costs you something.

Practice servant leadership in one place where you have influence: at home, at work, or at church.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus for giving his life as a ransom for you.
- Ask him to free you from the love of money or status.
- Ask him to teach you to serve.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 85

"You shall love the Lord your God with all your heart and with all your soul and with all your mind."

MATTHEW 22:37

DAY 590 · WEEK 85

Matthew 21:1-22:14

The Triumphal Entry; Temple cleansing; the wicked tenants

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Reading · 60 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Matthew 21:1-22:14. Jesus enters Jerusalem on a donkey, cleanses the temple, curses a fig tree, is challenged on his authority, and tells three parables of judgment. Read the entry in light of Zechariah 9:9, which you memorized last unit.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

This is the beginning of the final week of Jesus' earthly life. He enters Jerusalem to the shouts of the crowds, and what follows is a series of confrontations in and around the temple. The religious leaders, who see him as a threat, try to trap him. Jesus responds with parables that expose their rejection of God's messengers and of his Son.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Behold, your king is coming to you, humble, and mounted on a donkey" (21:5).
2. "Hosanna to the Son of David! Blessed is he who comes in the name of the Lord!" (21:9).
3. "My house shall be called a house of prayer, but you make it a den of robbers" (21:13).
4. "By what authority are you doing these things?" (21:23).
5. "But when the tenants saw the son, they said to themselves, This is the heir. Come, let us kill him and have his inheritance" (21:38).
6. "The stone that the builders rejected has become the cornerstone" (21:42).
7. "Therefore I tell you, the kingdom of God will be taken away from you and given to a people producing its fruits" (21:43).
8. "For many are called, but few are chosen" (22:14).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Jesus plans his entry. He sends for a donkey and a colt, and Matthew says this fulfilled the prophecy of Zechariah 9:9, the verse you memorized at the end of Unit 14. The king comes humble and on a donkey. The crowds spread cloaks and branches, and shout “Hosanna,” which means “save us,” quoting Psalm 118. They see him as the Son of David.

He goes straight to the temple and drives out the merchants. The temple was meant to be a house of prayer for all nations, and it had become a marketplace. He heals the blind and lame there, and the children shout his praise, while the leaders are indignant.

The cursed fig tree is a parable in action. It had leaves, which promised fruit, but no fruit. It pictures a religion with outward show and no reality. The leaders then challenge his authority, and he answers with a question about John’s baptism that they cannot answer without exposing themselves.

The parable of the two sons shows that tax collectors and prostitutes are entering the kingdom ahead of the religious leaders, because they repented. The parable of the wicked tenants is the clearest. The landowner sends servants, who are beaten and killed, and finally he sends his son. The tenants kill him to seize the inheritance. Jesus quotes Psalm 118: the stone the builders rejected becomes the cornerstone. The leaders perceive that he is speaking about them.

The wedding feast is the last parable. Those invited refuse, and the invitation goes out to everyone. But one man arrives without a wedding garment, and he is cast out. The garment pictures what God provides for entry. “Many are called, but few are chosen.”

STEP 5

Connection

Zechariah 9:9 and Psalm 118:25-26 stand behind the entry. Isaiah 56:7 and Jeremiah 7:11 are quoted at the temple cleansing. Isaiah 5:1-7 is the background to the vineyard parable. Psalm 118:22-23 is the cornerstone passage, also cited in Acts 4:11 and 1 Peter 2:4-8. Isaiah 61:10 speaks of being clothed with garments of salvation. Revelation 19:7-9 describes the marriage supper of the Lamb. Galatians 3:27: as many as were baptized into Christ have put on Christ.

STEP 6

Application

Welcome Jesus as the king who comes humbly. Is there an area where you want a more impressive king?

Ask whether your life has leaves without fruit. What is one practical step toward real fruit?

Think about the wedding garment: are you trusting in your own righteousness or in the clothing Christ provides?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Say “Hosanna” to the Son of David, and tell him why.
- Thank him for coming humbly to Jerusalem.
- Ask him to cleanse the temple of your own heart.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 85

“You shall love the Lord your God with all your heart and with all your soul and with all your mind.”

MATTHEW 22:37

DAY 591 · WEEK 85

Matthew 22:15-23:39

Controversies; the greatest commandment; woes to scribes

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Reading · 65 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Matthew 22:15-23:39. The leaders test Jesus with questions about taxes, the resurrection, and the greatest commandment. Then Jesus turns the tables and pronounces seven woes on the scribes and Pharisees. Read 22:34-40 slowly.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The final week in the temple courts is a series of tests. First the Pharisees and Herodians ask about taxes to Caesar, then the Sadducees ask about the resurrection, and then a lawyer asks about the greatest commandment. Jesus answers all of them with wisdom. Then he asks the question that silences his opponents, and he turns to the crowds and disciples to warn them about the hypocrisy of their leaders.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Render to Caesar the things that are Caesar’s, and to God the things that are God’s” (22:21).
2. “You are wrong, because you know neither the Scriptures nor the power of God” (22:29).
3. “He is not God of the dead, but of the living” (22:32).
4. “You shall love the Lord your God with all your heart and with all your soul and with all your mind” (22:37).
5. “On these two commandments depend all the Law and the Prophets” (22:40).
6. “The Lord said to my Lord, Sit at my right hand” (22:44).
7. “They preach, but do not practice” (23:3).

8 “Whoever exalts himself will be humbled, and whoever humbles himself will be exalted” (23:12).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Jesus answers the question about taxes with wisdom. The coin bears Caesar’s image, so give it to Caesar. But humans bear God’s image, so give yourselves to God. The Sadducees, who deny the resurrection, bring a trick question, and Jesus answers from the Scriptures they accept: God said, “I am the God of Abraham,” and he is the God of the living. The resurrection is rooted in who God is.

The lawyer asks which commandment is the greatest. Jesus gives two: love God with everything, and love your neighbor as yourself. All the law and the prophets hang on these. This is not a replacement for the law but its summary. The whole of the Old Testament is about love of God and neighbor.

Then Jesus asks his question about Psalm 110. If the Christ is David’s son, how does David call him Lord? No one could answer, and from that day, no one dared to ask him any more questions. The Messiah is both human and divine.

Chapter 23 is the most severe passage in the Gospels. Jesus warns the crowds and his disciples about the scribes and Pharisees. They sit on Moses’ seat, so their teaching from Scripture should be heeded, but their practice should not be imitated. They love honor, burden people with rules, and neglect justice, mercy, and faithfulness. “Woe to you, hypocrites!” occurs again and again. They clean the outside of the cup and are full of greed inside. They are whitewashed tombs.

Yet the chapter ends with sorrow, not just anger: “O Jerusalem, Jerusalem… How often would I have gathered your children together as a hen gathers her brood under her wings, and you were not willing!” The judgment comes from a broken heart. Even so, he promises that they will say, “Blessed is he who comes in the name of the Lord.”

STEP 5

Connection

Deuteronomy 6:5 and Leviticus 19:18 are the two commandments quoted. Exodus 3:6 is quoted about the God of the living. Psalm 110:1 is the psalm you read on Day 587. Micah 6:8 sums up justice, kindness, and walking humbly. Romans 13:8-10 says love is the fulfilling of the law. 1 John 4:19-21: we love because he first loved us. Luke 13:34-35 has the lament over Jerusalem. Philippians 2:3.

STEP 6

Application

Practice the two great commandments today: choose one concrete act of love for God and one for a neighbor.

Check yourself for hypocrisy: where do you say one thing and do another?

Remember that Jesus grieves over those who refuse him. Pray for someone who resists the gospel.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask Jesus to teach you to love God with all your heart, soul, and mind.
- Ask him to help you love a specific neighbor.
- Ask him to keep you from the hypocrisy he warns about.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 85

"You shall love the Lord your God with all your heart and with all your soul and with all your mind."

MATTHEW 22:37

DAY 592 · WEEK 85

Matthew 24:1-25:46

The Olivet Discourse; virgins, talents, sheep and goats

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Reading · 97 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Matthew 24:1-25:46. This is the Olivet Discourse, followed by three parables: the ten virgins, the talents, and the sheep and goats. It is a long reading, so take it in three parts. Notice the repeated call to watch and be ready.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

As Jesus leaves the temple, the disciples point out its buildings. He says that not one stone will be left on another. Later, on the Mount of Olives, they ask when this will happen and what will be the sign of his coming and the close of the age. Jesus' answer includes the destruction of Jerusalem in AD 70, and it also looks further to his return. The point of the chapters is not to give a timetable but to call for readiness.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "See that no one leads you astray. For many will come in my name, saying, I am the Christ" (24:4-5).
2. "But the one who endures to the end will be saved" (24:13).
3. "And this gospel of the kingdom will be proclaimed throughout the whole world as a testimony to all nations, and then the end will come" (24:14).
4. "Heaven and earth will pass away, but my words will not pass away" (24:35).
5. "But concerning that day and hour no one knows, not even the angels of heaven, nor the Son, but the Father only" (24:36).
6. "Watch therefore, for you do not know on what day your Lord is coming" (24:42).

7. “Well done, good and faithful servant. You have been faithful over a little; I will set you over much” (25:21).

8. “Truly, I say to you, as you did it to one of the least of these my brothers, you did it to me” (25:40).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The discourse mixes near and far. Jesus warns of false messiahs, wars, famines, persecution, and the abomination of desolation, details that were fulfilled in part in the destruction of Jerusalem in AD 70. He also speaks of his coming “like lightning” and the gathering of his elect. Scholars differ on how to divide the near and far. What is clear is the pattern: before the end there will be trouble, the gospel will go to all nations, and no one will know the day.

The repeated call is to be ready. The faithful servant is the one found working when the master returns. This is not paranoia but steady faithfulness.

Three parables apply the point. The ten virgins: five were wise and took extra oil, and five were foolish. When the bridegroom came at midnight, the foolish ones were shut out. Readiness cannot be borrowed at the last minute. The talents: a master entrusts money to three servants and goes away. Two invest and double it, and the third buries his out of fear. The master praises faithfulness and condemns the one who did nothing. We are to use what Jesus has entrusted to us.

The sheep and goats is the final scene of judgment. The Son of Man sits on his throne and separates the nations. The sheep are those who fed the hungry, welcomed the stranger, clothed the naked, and visited the sick and imprisoned, and they did so to Jesus without knowing it. The goats failed to do so. The standard is not a list of achievements but the fruit of a changed heart: love shown to the least of these, who are Christ’s brothers.

The discourse ends on a note of both warning and hope. The King will return. Those who are his will be welcomed into the kingdom prepared for them since the foundation of the world.

STEP 5

Connection

Daniel 7:13-14 and 9:27 stand behind the language of the Son of Man and the abomination. 1 Thessalonians 4:13-5:11 describes the Lord’s return and the call to be awake. 2 Peter 3:8-13 explains the delay. Luke 19:11-27 gives a similar parable of the minas. James 2:14-17 says faith without works is dead. Revelation 20:11-15 depicts the final judgment. Titus 2:13 speaks of waiting for the blessed hope.

STEP 6

Application

Ask what you have been entrusted with, such as time, gifts, resources, and relationships. How can you invest it for the King?

Do one concrete act of mercy for “the least of these” this week.

Live ready, not fearful: do today’s work faithfully, knowing that he is coming.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell Jesus you are watching and ready, or ask him to make you so.
- Ask him for the faithfulness that lasts like oil in a lamp.
- Ask him to show you how to care for the least of these.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 85

“You shall love the Lord your God with all your heart and with all your soul and with all your mind.”

MATTHEW 22:37

DAY 593 · WEEK 85

Psalm 118

Blessed is he who comes in the name of the LORD

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Psalm · 29 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 118. This is the last of the Hallel psalms, which Jews sang at Passover. It was likely sung by Jesus and the disciples on the night of the Last Supper. Read it as the psalm of the week you have just entered.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 118 is a thanksgiving liturgy for a king who has been delivered. Verses 22 to 29 were part of what the crowds shouted on Palm Sunday. Jesus quoted it in the parable of the tenants. The Hallel (Psalms 113 to 118) was sung at Passover, which makes it very likely that this was the last hymn Jesus sang before Gethsemane (Matthew 26:30).

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Give thanks to the LORD, for he is good; for his steadfast love endures forever!” (v. 1).
2. “Out of my distress I called on the LORD; the LORD answered me and set me free” (v. 5).
3. “The LORD is on my side; I will not fear. What can man do to me?” (v. 6).
4. “It is better to take refuge in the LORD than to trust in man” (v. 8).
5. “The LORD is my strength and my song; he has become my salvation” (v. 14).
6. “I shall not die, but I shall live, and recount the deeds of the LORD” (v. 17).
7. “The stone that the builders rejected has become the cornerstone” (v. 22).
8. “Blessed is he who comes in the name of the LORD!” (v. 26).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins and ends with the same refrain: “Give thanks to the LORD, for he is good.” Between those lines, a man who has been surrounded and nearly killed tells how God rescued him. “All nations surrounded me; in the name of the LORD I cut them off!” He was pushed hard, but the LORD helped him. “The LORD has disciplined me severely, but he has not given me over to death.”

Then he asks to enter the gates of righteousness to give thanks, and the main verses follow. The stone that the builders rejected has become the cornerstone. This is the Lord’s doing, and it is marvelous in our eyes. In the original setting, it probably referred to Israel, once despised by the nations, or to the Davidic king. In the New Testament it is applied to Jesus. The builders, the leaders of Israel, rejected him, and God made him the cornerstone of the new temple.

Then the crowd’s words: “Save us, we pray, O LORD!” (Hosanna) and “Blessed is he who comes in the name of the LORD!” On Palm Sunday, the crowd shouted these words to Jesus. They did not yet understand how he would save. The one who comes in the LORD’s name would enter the gates of Jerusalem and go to a cross.

Think about Jesus singing this psalm on the night he was betrayed. “The LORD is on my side; I will not fear.” “I shall not die, but I shall live.” “Bind the festal sacrifice with cords, up to the horns of the altar!” The psalm of the rejected stone was sung by the rejected stone, on his way to be rejected.

And it ends with praise. “You are my God, and I will give thanks to you.” The cross is not the end.

STEP 5

Connection

Matthew 21:9, 21:42, and 23:39 quote this psalm. Matthew 26:30 says that after singing a hymn they went out to the Mount of Olives. Acts 4:11-12 and 1 Peter 2:6-8 apply the cornerstone to Jesus. Ephesians 2:20-22 describes the household of God built on the cornerstone. Romans 8:31: if God is for us, who can be against us? Hebrews 13:6 quotes verse 6. Hebrews 12:2.

STEP 6

Application

Sing or read Psalm 118:1 and 29 as a frame for your day. Begin and end with thanks.

Remember a time when God brought you out of distress. Tell someone about it.

Pray verse 25, “Save us, we pray,” for your church and for someone who needs rescue.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Give thanks to God for his steadfast love.
- Tell him: “The LORD is on my side; I will not fear.”
- Thank him for the stone the builders rejected.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 85

“You shall love the Lord your God with all your heart and with all your soul and with all your mind.”

MATTHEW 22:37

DAY 594 · WEEK 85

Matthew 26:1-46

The plot; the anointing; the Last Supper; Gethsemane

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Reading · 46 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Matthew 26:1-46. The plot against Jesus, the anointing at Bethany, Judas's betrayal, the Last Supper, Peter's denial predicted, and Gethsemane. Read the words of institution (26:26-29) and the prayer in the garden (26:36-46) slowly.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

It is Passover week. The religious leaders are plotting to arrest Jesus quietly. At the same time, a woman anoints him with costly perfume, Judas bargains to betray him, and Jesus shares the Passover meal with his disciples. In the garden afterward, he prays in anguish. Matthew shows that everything is happening according to the Scriptures, and that Jesus goes to the cross willingly.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "You know that after two days the Passover is coming, and the Son of Man will be delivered up to be crucified" (26:2).
2. "Why this waste? For this could have been sold for a large sum and given to the poor" (26:8-9).
3. "What will you give me if I deliver him to you?" (26:15).
4. "Take, eat; this is my body" (26:26).
5. "For this is my blood of the covenant, which is poured out for many for the forgiveness of sins" (26:28).
6. "Even if I must die with you, I will not deny you" (26:35).
7. "My soul is very sorrowful, even to death; remain here, and watch with me" (26:38).

8 “My Father, if it be possible, let this cup pass from me; nevertheless, not as I will, but as you will” (26:39).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The chapter moves between devotion and betrayal. A woman pours an expensive jar of ointment on Jesus’ head, and the disciples object to the waste. Jesus defends her: she has prepared him for burial, and her act will be remembered. Immediately afterward, Judas goes to the chief priests and sells Jesus for thirty pieces of silver. The price recalls Zechariah 11:12, the price of a slave.

At the Passover meal, Jesus predicts that one of them will betray him. Each asks, “Is it I, Lord?” Then he takes bread and wine and gives them new meaning. The bread is his body and the cup is his blood of the covenant, poured out for the forgiveness of sins. This is the new covenant promised in Jeremiah 31. The Passover lamb saved Israel from judgment, and Jesus is the Lamb whose blood saves his people. He also promises that he will drink it new with them in the Father’s kingdom.

On the way to the Mount of Olives, he tells the disciples that they will all fall away. Peter protests that he will never deny him. Jesus says that before the rooster crows, he will deny him three times.

In Gethsemane, we see Jesus in anguish. “My soul is very sorrowful, even to death.” He falls on his face and prays, “Let this cup pass from me.” The cup is the cup of God’s wrath against sin. Yet he adds, “Not as I will, but as you will.” The second Adam, in a garden, submits to the Father’s will where the first Adam rebelled. He prays three times, and the disciples sleep. Then he stands: “Rise, let us be going; see, my betrayer is at hand.”

STEP 5

Connection

Exodus 12 describes the first Passover. Jeremiah 31:31-34 promises the new covenant. Zechariah 11:12-13 and 13:7 are fulfilled in the thirty pieces and the scattering of the sheep. Isaiah 51:17 describes the cup of the LORD’s wrath. Hebrews 5:7-8 describes Jesus’ prayers with loud cries and tears. 1 Corinthians 11:23-26 gives Paul’s account of the Lord’s Supper. Genesis 3 and Romans 5:19 contrast Adam’s disobedience with Christ’s obedience. Luke 22:44.

STEP 6

Application

If you are able, take the Lord's Supper this week, and think about what "the forgiveness of sins" cost him.

In your own Gethsemane, whatever that may be, pray as Jesus did: "Not as I will, but as you will."

Ask where you have said, "I will never deny you," and been overconfident.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus for the bread and cup given for the forgiveness of your sins.
- Ask him to keep you awake and praying when you are tempted to sleep.
- Tell him what cup you are afraid to drink, and pray, "Not my will but yours."

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 85

"You shall love the Lord your God with all your heart and with all your soul and with all your mind."

MATTHEW 22:37

DAY 595 · WEEK 85

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Matthew 22:37 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"You shall love the Lord your God with all your heart and with all your soul and with all your mind."

MATTHEW 22:37

REST

Meditation

A lawyer tried to test Jesus with a question: which commandment in the law is the greatest? Jesus quoted the Shema from Deuteronomy 6, the words every Jewish child learned.

"You shall love." The center of the law is love. Love is a command, which means it is a settled direction of the will as well as a feeling. We are commanded because love is owed, and because God knows our hearts will wander if left alone.

"The Lord your God." The object of love is the Lord, and he is our God, in covenant relationship. He is not an idea or a force. He is a person who has made himself known and who loves us first.

"With all your heart." The heart in Hebrew thought is the center of the person, including will and desire. To love with all the heart is to desire God above all.

“And with all your soul.” The soul is the whole life. To love with all the soul is to give our lives and energy to him.

“And with all your mind.” The mind is our thinking and understanding. Christianity is not anti-intellectual. We are meant to think about God and his word, and to love him with our minds.

The whole person is to be engaged. Nothing is left over. This is the great and first commandment, and Jesus says that the second is like it: love your neighbor as yourself. No one has ever fully kept it except Jesus. He loved the Father perfectly and loved us to the cross. Say this verse each morning and ask him to grow your love.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you walked with Jesus toward Jerusalem and into Holy Week. You heard his teaching on marriage, children, and wealth, and saw the rich young man walk away. You learned that greatness in the kingdom means serving, since the Son of Man came to give his life as a ransom for many. You watched the king enter Jerusalem on a donkey, clean out the temple, and tell parables about wicked tenants and a wedding feast. You heard the two great commandments and the seven woes. In the Olivet Discourse, he called you to be ready: like the wise virgins, faithful servants, and those who serve the least of these. Psalm 118 gave you the words the crowds sang and Jesus likely sang that final night. At the Last Supper, he gave you his body and blood of the new covenant, and in Gethsemane he prayed, “Not as I will, but as you will.”

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Jesus summed up the law in two commandments: love God and love neighbor. Which of the two do you find harder right now, and why?

In the parable of the sheep and goats, the righteous served Christ without realizing it. Who are “the least of these” near you, and what is one concrete way to serve them?

At the Last Supper, Jesus said his blood is poured out “for the forgiveness of sins.” What does it mean to you personally that he drank the cup of judgment for you?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask Jesus to help you love God with all your heart and your neighbor as yourself.

Thank him for the cup he drank for you.

Rest in him.

DAY 596 · WEEK 86

Matthew 26:47-27:31

Arrest; trials before the Sanhedrin and Pilate

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Reading · 81 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Matthew 26:47-27:31. Jesus is arrested, tried by the Sanhedrin, denied by Peter, handed over to Pilate, and mocked by soldiers. Watch how Jesus responds to each trial, and contrast his behavior with that of Peter and Judas.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

It is the night and early morning of Good Friday. Jesus is arrested in the garden by a crowd sent by the chief priests, led by Judas. He is taken to the high priest Caiaphas, where he is tried at night. At dawn he is delivered to the Roman governor Pilate, because only Rome could carry out a death sentence. The man who had healed and taught is now abandoned, mocked, and condemned.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Friend, do what you came to do” (26:50).
2. “Put your sword back into its place. For all who take the sword will perish by the sword” (26:52).
3. “Do you think that I cannot appeal to my Father, and he will at once send me more than twelve legions of angels?” (26:53).
4. “I adjure you by the living God, tell us whether you are the Christ, the Son of God” (26:63).
5. “You have said so. But I tell you, from now on you will see the Son of Man seated at the right hand of Power” (26:64).
6. “And he went out and wept bitterly” (26:75).

7. “I have sinned by betraying innocent blood” (27:4).
8. “His blood be on us and on our children” (27:25).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Everything in the arrest shows that Jesus is in control. He tells Peter to put away his sword. He could call twelve legions of angels, but then the Scriptures could not be fulfilled. He goes willingly. All the disciples flee.

Before the Sanhedrin, the trial is a sham. False witnesses cannot agree. Finally the high priest asks under oath if he is the Christ. Jesus answers by combining Psalm 110 and Daniel 7: he will be seen seated at the right hand of Power and coming on the clouds of heaven. The high priest tears his robes and declares blasphemy. The council spits on him and strikes him. Jesus is condemned for telling the truth about who he is.

Meanwhile, Peter denies him three times as Jesus predicted, and when the rooster crows, he goes out and weeps bitterly. Judas, too, is filled with remorse and returns the silver, saying, “I have sinned.” But he goes and hangs himself. The difference between Peter and Judas is not in their sin but where they turned. Peter would later be restored. Judas despaired. True repentance turns to Christ and is met by his mercy.

Before Pilate, Jesus is silent when accused. Pilate knows that the leaders delivered him up out of envy. His wife sends a message: “Have nothing to do with that righteous man.” Pilate offers to release Barabbas or Jesus. The crowd chooses Barabbas, a criminal. The innocent one takes the guilty man’s place. Pilate washes his hands and has Jesus flogged. The soldiers mock him with a scarlet robe, a crown of thorns, and a reed scepter, and kneel to him in mockery. They did not know they were saying the truth: here is the King.

STEP 5

Connection

Isaiah 53:7 says “like a lamb that is led to the slaughter… he opened not his mouth.” Psalm 22:7-8 describes the mocking. Daniel 7:13-14 and Psalm 110:1 stand behind Jesus’ answer. 1 Peter 2:21-24 says Christ suffered for you, leaving you an example. 2 Corinthians 5:21: for our sake he made him to be sin who knew no sin. Luke 22:61-62 adds that the Lord turned and looked at Peter. Galatians 3:13. Hebrews 12:2-3.

STEP 6

Application

Place yourself in Peter’s sandals. Where have you denied Jesus by silence or by fear? Bring it to him, and know that he restores.

Consider Barabbas: Jesus took the place of a guilty man. You are Barabbas. Let that humble and move you.

Notice the silence of Jesus before his accusers, and ask the Spirit to give you patience when you are misjudged.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus for going willingly to be arrested for you.
- Confess where you have denied him.
- Ask him to restore you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 86

"Go therefore and make disciples of all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit, teaching them to observe all that I have commanded you. And behold, I am with you always, to the end of the age."

MATTHEW 28:19-20

DAY 597 · WEEK 86

Matthew 27:32-66

The crucifixion; the burial, the King dies for his people

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Reading · 35 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Matthew 27:32-66. Jesus is crucified, mocked, abandoned, and dies. The temple curtain is torn, the earth shakes, and a centurion confesses. Read this slowly and quietly. Then notice the burial and the guard at the tomb.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Jesus is led to Golgotha, "the place of a skull," and crucified between two robbers. Matthew tells the story with restraint, but with signs that show its cosmic meaning. Darkness covers the land, the temple veil splits, the earth quakes, and the dead are raised. The King dies for his people.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "And over his head they put the charge against him, which read, This is Jesus, the King of the Jews" (27:37).
2. "He saved others; he cannot save himself. He is the King of Israel; let him come down now from the cross, and we will believe in him" (27:42).
3. "Now from the sixth hour there was darkness over all the land until the ninth hour" (27:45).
4. "Eli, Eli, lema sabachthani? That is, My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?" (27:46).
5. "And Jesus cried out again with a loud voice and yielded up his spirit" (27:50).
6. "And behold, the curtain of the temple was torn in two, from top to bottom" (27:51).
7. "Truly this was the Son of God!" (27:54).

8 “Make it as secure as you can” (27:65).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The mocking is cruel and ironic. The leaders say, “He saved others; he cannot save himself.” They are right in a way they do not realize. He did not save himself precisely because he was saving others. The sign over his head, “King of the Jews,” is written as a mockery and is true.

At noon, darkness falls over the land for three hours. At the ninth hour, Jesus cries, “My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?” This is the opening of Psalm 22. It is the cry of one bearing the weight of sin. The Son who has never been separated from the Father experiences the abandonment that we deserve. This is the heart of the atonement. He bore the wrath for his people.

Then he yields up his spirit. Matthew records what follows. The temple curtain, which separated the Holy of Holies from the people, is torn from top to bottom, by God. The way into God’s presence is open. The earth shakes, the rocks split, and tombs open: the power of death is broken. A Roman centurion who watched him die says, “Truly this was the Son of God!” The first confession after the cross is from a Gentile.

Women who followed Jesus watch from a distance. Joseph of Arimathea, a rich disciple, asks Pilate for the body, wraps it in clean linen, and lays it in his own new tomb. The chief priests, who remembered that Jesus said he would rise on the third day, ask Pilate for a guard and seal the stone. They do all they can to keep him in the grave. But human security cannot stop God’s plan.

The chapter ends in silence. It is Saturday. The King is dead and buried. The disciples are scattered. And the reader holds their breath.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 22 describes the crucifixion in detail, from the cry of abandonment to the mocking and the casting of lots. Isaiah 53:4-6 and 10-12 describe the servant bearing our sins. Hebrews 10:19-22 says that through the curtain, that is, his flesh, we have confidence to enter the holy places. Galatians 3:13 says Christ became a curse for us. Romans 5:8. 1 Peter 3:18. 2 Corinthians 5:21. Mark 15:39 gives the centurion’s confession.

STEP 6

Application

Spend a few minutes in silence with this chapter. Let the weight of it settle.

Say aloud, “He did this for me,” and thank him specifically.

Because the curtain is torn, come boldly into God’s presence in prayer today.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus for being forsaken so that you never would be.
- Tell him what it means that he bore your sin and the wrath you deserved.
- Sit in silence for a moment, and let it settle.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 86

“Go therefore and make disciples of all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit, teaching them to observe all that I have commanded you. And behold, I am with you always, to the end of the age.”

MATTHEW 28:19-20

DAY 598 · WEEK 86

Matthew 28:1-20

The resurrection; the Great Commission, all authority, all nations

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Reading · 20 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Matthew 28:1-20. The women find the tomb empty, the risen Jesus meets them, the guards are bribed, and Jesus commissions his disciples on a mountain. This is the climax of the Gospel. Read the Great Commission aloud.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Early on the first day of the week, Mary Magdalene and the other Mary go to the tomb. Matthew's Gospel, which began with "God with us," ends with the risen Lord promising to be with his people always. The same Jesus who was rejected and killed now claims all authority in heaven and on earth.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "And behold, there was a great earthquake, for an angel of the Lord, descending from heaven… rolled back the stone and sat on it" (28:2).
2. "He is not here, for he has risen, as he said. Come, see the place where he lay" (28:6).
3. "So they departed quickly from the tomb with fear and great joy, and ran to tell his disciples" (28:8).
4. "Do not be afraid; go and tell my brothers to go to Galilee, and there they will see me" (28:10).
5. "And when they saw him they worshiped him, but some doubted" (28:17).
6. "All authority in heaven and on earth has been given to me" (28:18).
7. "Go therefore and make disciples of all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit" (28:19).

8 “And behold, I am with you always, to the end of the age” (28:20).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The resurrection is announced by the angel: “He has risen, as he said.” The tomb is empty, and the grave clothes are no longer needed. The women are told to go and tell the disciples. On the way, Jesus meets them, and they take hold of his feet and worship him. Notice that he calls the disciples “my brothers,” even after they abandoned him. He is gracious to those who failed.

The guards report to the chief priests, who bribe them to say the disciples stole the body. Matthew notes that this story was still spread among the Jews “to this day.” The empty tomb was too well known to deny. The only alternative was to invent a story. The resurrection is a fact that must be explained.

On the mountain in Galilee, the eleven see him and worship, though some doubt. Jesus does not rebuke them. He draws near and speaks. His words are the climax of the Gospel. First, authority: “All authority in heaven and on earth has been given to me.” This is the fulfillment of Daniel 7:13-14, where the Son of Man receives dominion over all peoples. Then a command: make disciples of all nations. The mission that began with Abraham, “in you all the families of the earth shall be blessed,” now goes out to the world. The method is baptizing and teaching them to obey all that Jesus commanded. Finally, a promise: “I am with you always, to the end of the age.”

The book has come full circle. It began with Immanuel, “God with us,” and ends with “I am with you.” The King has conquered death, and his people are sent out in his authority and presence.

STEP 5

Connection

Daniel 7:13-14 is the background to “all authority.” Genesis 12:3 promised blessing for all families. Romans 1:4 says Jesus was declared to be the Son of God in power by his resurrection. 1 Corinthians 15:3-8 lists the appearances. Acts 1:8 repeats the commission. Isaiah 7:14 and Matthew 1:23 give Immanuel. Ephesians 1:20-22 describes Christ raised and seated above all rule. Revelation 7:9. John 20:21.

STEP 6

Application

Celebrate. Say aloud, “He is risen,” and let it be joy.

Think of one person you can invite or encourage to follow Jesus. Take a small step this week.

When you doubt, as some did, remember that Jesus came to them and spoke. Ask him to draw near.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Praise Jesus that he is risen as he said.

Thank him for all authority and the promise to be with you always.

Ask him to send you to someone to share his good news.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 86

"Go therefore and make disciples of all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit, teaching them to observe all that I have commanded you. And behold, I am with you always, to the end of the age."

MATTHEW 28:19-20

DAY 599 · WEEK 86

Deuteronomy 6:4; Matthew 28:18-20; 2 Corinthians 13:14

The Trinity

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Doctrine

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Deuteronomy 6:4, Matthew 28:18-20, and 2 Corinthians 13:14. Today is a doctrinal pause on the Trinity. Notice that Deuteronomy says God is one, and the two New Testament verses name the Father, Son, and Holy Spirit together.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The Bible never uses the word "Trinity," but it teaches the truth the word describes. In Deuteronomy, Israel confesses, "The LORD our God, the LORD is one." In the Great Commission, Jesus tells us to baptize in the singular "name" of the Father, Son, and Holy Spirit. Paul ends 2 Corinthians with a blessing that names all three. The church has summarized this teaching in its creeds.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Hear, O Israel: The LORD our God, the LORD is one" (Deuteronomy 6:4).
2. "Baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit" (Matthew 28:19).
3. "All authority in heaven and on earth has been given to me" (Matthew 28:18).
4. "Teaching them to observe all that I have commanded you" (Matthew 28:20).
5. "And behold, I am with you always, to the end of the age" (Matthew 28:20).
6. "The grace of the Lord Jesus Christ" (2 Corinthians 13:14).
7. "And the love of God" (2 Corinthians 13:14).

8 “And the fellowship of the Holy Spirit be with you all” (2 Corinthians 13:14).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

The Trinity is the biblical teaching that there is one God who eternally exists as three distinct persons, the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit, who are each fully God, and who share one divine essence. The persons are not three gods, and they are not three modes or masks of one person. The Father is not the Son, the Son is not the Spirit, and the Spirit is not the Father, yet there is one God. The persons are equal in glory and eternal, and they relate to one another in love: the Father eternally begets the Son, and the Spirit eternally proceeds from the Father and the Son. In salvation, the Father plans and sends, the Son accomplishes redemption, and the Spirit applies it.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Start with Deuteronomy 6:4, the Shema. Israel’s creed was that the LORD is one. In a world of many gods, this was the foundation of Israel’s faith. The New Testament does not abandon it. Instead it reveals that this one God has a fuller inner life than Israel knew.

In Matthew 28:19, Jesus commands baptism “in the name” (singular) of the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit. A single name for three persons, side by side, as equals. If the Son and the Spirit were mere creatures, to place them alongside the Father in this way would be blasphemy. Jesus also claims “all authority in heaven and on earth,” and promises to be present everywhere with his people always, which only God can do.

In 2 Corinthians 13:14, Paul names the three together in a blessing. He does not explain it, but assumes it. The blessing is the grace of the Lord Jesus Christ, the love of God, and the fellowship of the Holy Spirit. Each person gives something, and all are equally God. Similar patterns appear throughout the New Testament, at Jesus’ baptism (the Father speaks, the Son is baptized, the Spirit descends), and in Ephesians 1, where the Father chooses, the Son redeems, and the Spirit seals.

Why does this matter? First, it means that God is love in himself. Before creation, the Father, Son, and Spirit shared perfect love. God did not need us to be loving. Second, it means that salvation is the work of the whole Trinity. Third, it means that when we worship Jesus, we are not violating monotheism, and when we pray by the Spirit we are speaking with God. The doctrine is a mystery, something we receive and adore, not something we fully comprehend. But it is the shape of the gospel.

STEP 5

Connection

John 1:1-3 and 14 reveal the Word who was with God and was God. John 14:16-17 mentions the Father, Son, and the Spirit as another Helper. Genesis 1:26 says “Let us make man.” Matthew 3:16-17 shows all three at Jesus’ baptism. Ephesians 1:3-14 sets out the work of each person. Romans 8:9-11 speaks of the Spirit of God and the Spirit of Christ. 1 Peter 1:2. Isaiah 6:8. Hebrews 9:14.

STEP 6

Application

Pray to each person of the Trinity this week: thank the Father for his love, the Son for his grace, and the Spirit for his fellowship.

Use the blessing in 2 Corinthians 13:14 to end a prayer or bless a loved one.

Resist the urge to reduce the Trinity to a neat illustration. Worship the mystery.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Worship the Father, Son, and Spirit, one God, in your own words.
- Thank the Father for his love, the Son for his grace, and the Spirit for his fellowship.
- Ask them to help you know each more.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 86

“Go therefore and make disciples of all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit, teaching them to observe all that I have commanded you. And behold, I am with you always, to the end of the age.”

MATTHEW 28:19-20

DAY 600 · WEEK 86

Matthew 28:18-20; Romans 6:1-4; Acts 2:38-41; Colossians 2:11-12

The Sacraments, Baptism

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Doctrine

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Matthew 28:18-20, Romans 6:1-4, Acts 2:38-41, and Colossians 2:11-12. Today is a doctrinal pause on baptism. Notice what each passage says baptism pictures and what it commits us to.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Jesus commanded baptism as part of making disciples. The early church practiced it from the first day: in Acts 2, three thousand were baptized after Peter's sermon. In his letters, Paul explains what baptism means. Christians have disagreed about some aspects of baptism, particularly about who should be baptized and the mode. This lesson focuses on what the Scriptures say about its meaning, and notes where traditions differ.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit" (Matthew 28:19).
2. "Do you not know that all of us who have been baptized into Christ Jesus were baptized into his death?" (Romans 6:3).
3. "We were buried therefore with him by baptism into death" (Romans 6:4).
4. "So that… we too might walk in newness of life" (Romans 6:4).
5. "Repent and be baptized every one of you in the name of Jesus Christ for the forgiveness of your sins" (Acts 2:38).
6. "And you will receive the gift of the Holy Spirit" (Acts 2:38).

7. “So those who received his word were baptized, and there were added that day about three thousand souls” (Acts 2:41).

8. “Having been buried with him in baptism, in which you were also raised with him through faith in the powerful working of God” (Colossians 2:12).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

Baptism is the sign, commanded by Christ, of entrance into the new covenant community. It pictures union with Christ in his death and resurrection, the washing away of sin, and the gift of the Spirit, and it publicly marks a person as belonging to the triune God and his people. Baptism does not save by itself; salvation comes by grace through faith. But baptism is not optional, for it is Christ’s command and the normal response of faith. Christians have differed on whether the proper subjects are believers only, or also the infant children of believers, and on the mode of baptism. Reformed churches have held both views. All agree that baptism is a gift to be received with faith and that it points to Christ.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Baptism begins with a command. After the resurrection, Jesus told the disciples to make disciples by baptizing and teaching. It is not an extra for the especially devoted but a normal part of becoming a disciple. It is done in the name of the triune God, which means the person is brought under the ownership and protection of the Father, Son, and Holy Spirit.

Romans 6 gives the central meaning. Paul is answering the question, “Should we continue in sin that grace may abound?” He says no, because in baptism we were united with Christ in his death and burial, and raised to walk in newness of life. Baptism is a picture of the gospel: death to the old life and resurrection to the new. Colossians 2:11-12 says the same: buried with him in baptism and raised with him through faith. The faith is key. Baptism is a sign of what God does for those who believe.

On the day of Pentecost, Peter says to repent and be baptized for the forgiveness of sins, and promises the gift of the Spirit. Baptism goes with repentance and faith. Notice that the promise is “for you and for your children,” which is where the different traditions find support for their practice. Those who baptize only professing believers see baptism as the outward sign of an inward faith that has already begun. Those who baptize infants of believers see it as a covenant sign like circumcision, promising what God will do. Both agree that the sign is empty without faith and that the reality is Christ.

For a new believer, baptism is a joyful step. If you have not been baptized, talk with your pastor. If you have, remember it: you were marked as Christ’s.

STEP 5

Connection

Genesis 17:9-14 describes circumcision as the sign of the old covenant. Galatians 3:26-29 says all who are baptized into Christ have put on Christ. 1 Peter 3:21 says baptism now saves you as an appeal to God for a good conscience through the resurrection of Jesus. Acts 8:36-39 and 16:31-34 record baptisms. Titus 3:5. Ephesians 4:4-6 speaks of one Lord, one faith, one baptism. Mark 16:16.

STEP 6

Application

If you have not been baptized, speak to a pastor or leader about it this week.

If you have been baptized, remember the day, and thank God for the promise it signified.

When you struggle with sin, remember Romans 6: you are united with Christ, dead to sin and alive to God.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for baptism and what it shows about your washing and new life.
- Tell him where you need to remember your baptism.
- Pray for those who have not been baptized.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 86

"Go therefore and make disciples of all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit, teaching them to observe all that I have commanded you. And behold, I am with you always, to the end of the age."

MATTHEW 28:19-20

DAY 601 · WEEK 86

Review and Reflection

Unit 15 review, The New Covenant Inaugurated, Matthew

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Review

MEMORY

Unit Verse

> "You are the Christ, the Son of the living God."
>
> MATTHEW 16:16

REST

Meditation

Peter spoke these words in the region of Caesarea Philippi, a place full of temples to pagan gods. Jesus had asked, "Who do you say that I am?" and Peter answered for the group.

"You are the Christ." The word means the Anointed One, the Messiah, the king who was promised to David and for whom Israel had waited. Peter is saying that all the Old Testament hopes are fulfilled in Jesus. Everything you read in the Old Testament, the promised seed, the prophet like Moses, the son of David, the servant, and the king, was pointing to him.

"The Son of the living God." This phrase goes further. "Son of God" was a title for the king, but Peter's words, heard with the later Gospel, mean more. And he says "the living God," in contrast to the dead idols all around. Jesus is the Son of the one real, living God.

Jesus answered that this was not revealed by flesh and blood but by the Father in heaven. Faith is a gift. If you confess Jesus as the Christ, the Son of the living God, it is because the Father has opened your eyes.

And on this confession, Jesus said he would build his church. The church is a community of people who say what Peter said. Carry this sentence with you as the center of the whole unit. Every chapter of Matthew is meant to bring you to say it from the heart.

LOOK BACK

Unit Recap

Unit 15 opened the New Testament with Matthew's Gospel, and it showed that Jesus is the one for whom the whole Old Testament was waiting. His genealogy gathered Abraham and David. He was the new Israel, called out of Egypt, baptized in the Jordan, and tested in the wilderness, where he answered every temptation with Scripture. He was the new Moses, who gave the Sermon on the Mount from a mountain, showing that the law was always aimed at the heart and that he came to fulfill it, not abolish it. He taught us to pray to our Father, to seek first the kingdom, and to build our lives on the rock. His miracles showed the kingdom's power over disease, nature, demons, sin, and death, and his parables showed that it begins small and grows. Peter confessed that he is the Christ, the Son of the living God, and Jesus began to teach that the Christ must suffer. On the mountain the Father said, "Listen to him." In Jerusalem he rode in as the humble king, taught the two great commandments, and warned of judgment. At the Last Supper he gave his body and blood for the new covenant. At the cross, he bore the Father's wrath, the veil was torn, and the way into God's presence was opened. On the third day he rose and sent his disciples to all nations with all authority and with his presence. Two doctrinal days taught the Trinity and baptism. The King has come, and the kingdom has been inaugurated. The rest of the New Testament shows how it spreads.

REFLECT

Review Questions

How does Matthew's genealogy establish Jesus as the fulfillment of the OT covenants?

Think of Matthew 1:1 and the three sets of fourteen. What do Abraham and David represent, and why do the four women matter?

What does the Sermon on the Mount reveal about the relationship between law and gospel?

Think of the Beatitudes for the poor in spirit, the demand to go beyond the letter of the law in 5:21-48, and the impossible standard in 5:48. How does it drive us to Christ?

What does it mean that Jesus came not to abolish the law but to fulfill it?

Look at Matthew 5:17-20 and 22:37-40. How does Jesus keep the law, complete it, and bring it to its goal?

How does Matthew present the death and resurrection of Jesus as the climax of Israel's story?

Consider the Last Supper and the new covenant, the cry from Psalm 22, the torn veil, the centurion, and the Great Commission.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for Jesus, the Christ, the Son of the living God.

Tell him what you have seen in the King through Matthew.

Ask him to keep the unit verse before you.

DAY 602 · WEEK 86

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Matthew 28:19-20 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"Go therefore and make disciples of all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit, teaching them to observe all that I have commanded you. And behold, I am with you always, to the end of the age."

MATTHEW 28:19-20

REST

Meditation

These are the last words of Matthew's Gospel, spoken by the risen Lord. They sum up what the church exists to do and the promise that makes it possible.

"Go therefore." The "therefore" connects to the claim in the previous verse: all authority belongs to Jesus. Because he is Lord of all, we go. The mission rests on his authority and not on our ability.

"And make disciples of all nations." The main command is to make disciples, followers and learners of Jesus. "Go," "baptize," and "teach" all serve this. And it is for all nations, every people and language. The blessing promised to Abraham now goes out to the world.

“Baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit.” New disciples are brought into the community of the triune God and his people.

“Teaching them to observe all that I have commanded you.” Discipleship is about obedience and not just information. It takes time, and it includes the whole of Jesus’ teaching, including the Sermon on the Mount.

“And behold, I am with you always, to the end of the age.” The promise is the secret to all of it. We are not sent alone. The one with all authority is with us in every place and every year until he comes. “Behold” tells us to look at this and take courage.

You may not be going to another country, but you are called to make disciples where you are: at home, work, school, and church. Say this verse as a commission and as a comfort.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you walked through the last days of Jesus’ ministry in Matthew. You saw him teach about marriage, wealth, and servant leadership, and give his life as a ransom for many. You watched the king enter Jerusalem on a donkey, answer his enemies with parables and wisdom, and give the two great commandments. In the Olivet Discourse, he called you to be ready and faithful until he returns. In Psalm 118, you read the song of the rejected stone. You sat at the Last Supper, heard the words of the new covenant, and watched him pray in Gethsemane. You followed him through the trials, the mockery, and the cross, and you stood at the empty tomb to hear the Great Commission. Two doctrinal days gave you the Trinity and baptism. Together, they show that the King has come, died, and risen, and that he sends his people to the nations with his presence.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

The Great Commission says to make disciples of all nations. Who is one person in your life that you could invest in as a disciple, or from whom you could learn as a disciple?

Jesus promises, “I am with you always.” In what situation do you most need to believe that promise right now?

Matthew began with Immanuel, “God with us,” and ended with “I am with you always.” How does that frame change the way you read the whole Gospel?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus that all authority is his and he is with you always.

Ask him to send you to make disciples where you are.

Tell him who you will begin with.